



SHE CODE AFRICA · RESEARCH REPORT · 2026

The State of Women in African Tech Report 2026

From participation to power - what it takes for women to enter Africa's technology economy, and what it takes to rise within it.

206 women · 14 African countries · Quantitative survey and qualitative interviews

Published by She Code Africa

Bridging the gender gap in African technology since 2016



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EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW

Abstract

Africa's technology economy is expanding. Women are present within it - but presence is not the same as access.

Africa's technology economy is expanding across sectors, creating new opportunities for employment, entrepreneurship and innovation. Women are already part of this growth, working across engineering, product, marketing, operations, design, data, research, business and other functions that increasingly shape the continent's digital economy. Yet being present in the sector does not mean having equal access to opportunity, progression, leadership or capital.

African women are not struggling to enter technology. They are struggling to advance within it.

Across career progression, compensation, leadership and entrepreneurship, the same pattern repeats: individual effort, skill and ambition consistently outpace what the institutions around women are set up to reward. Women are building their capability. The ecosystem is not yet built to convert it.

The State of Women in African Tech Report 2026 examines what it takes for women to enter the tech sector, build sustainable careers and participate meaningfully in the opportunities being created across Africa. It looks at how women find their way into tech, what motivates the transition, the barriers they encounter early in their careers and, critically, what happens after entry. The research also considers progression, compensation, workplace culture, mentorship, leadership, entrepreneurship, access to capital and the role played by employers, communities, educational institutions, governments and investors.

The report is based on primary research involving 206 women across 14 African countries, combining quantitative survey responses with qualitative interviews with women and professionals working across the technology ecosystem. The research captures participants at different career stages and in both technical and non-technical roles, reflecting the range of pathways through which women now enter and build in technology.

The findings describe a workforce that is actively building its own skills and adapting to a rapidly changing industry. Many respondents entered tech through communities, self-directed learning and other routes outside traditional technical education. Curiosity and a desire to solve problems are strong motivations for entering the sector, while mentorship, access to first employment opportunities, financial constraints and the availability of meaningful career pathways continue to shape women's experiences.



The research also looks beyond entry, to the more difficult question: what happens once a woman has secured a place in the industry. Whether she receives meaningful responsibility, recognition, mentorship and sponsorship; whether progression is transparent; whether she can access leadership and decision-making opportunities; and whether the wider ecosystem provides the conditions needed to build businesses and careers over the long term, not just get a foot in the door.

As artificial intelligence becomes increasingly embedded in how work is performed, the report considers how women are responding to these changes and the skills they believe will matter in the years ahead. Their responses point to both enthusiasm about the opportunities created by emerging technologies and concerns around skills obsolescence, data privacy, ethics, bias and displacement.

The State of Women in African Tech Report 2026 brings these experiences together to provide a clearer picture of where women stand in Africa's technology economy today, what is genuinely moving them forward, and where the gaps remain significant. It is intended to inform better decisions by employers, policymakers, investors, educators, technology communities and the other institutions shaping the sector's future.

THE RESEARCH AT A GLANCE

206

women surveyed across the continent

14

African countries represented

71%

of respondents are within their first five years in tech

53.4%

entered tech through communities or self-directed learning



HOW THE RESEARCH WAS CONDUCTED

Methodology

Primary quantitative and qualitative research, situated within secondary evidence on Africa's digital economy.

The State of Women in African Tech Report 2026 was designed and conducted by She Code Africa, drawing on its work building and supporting women in technology across the continent since 2016. The research examines how women are entering, building careers, progressing and creating opportunities within Africa's technology ecosystem, looking across the different stages of that journey - from education and entry into the sector to workplace experience, career progression, leadership, entrepreneurship, ecosystem support and preparation for emerging technologies.

Respondents were recruited through public distribution, reaching women across She Code Africa's network as well as partner communities, professional networks and open channels across the continent, in order to capture a range of experiences beyond any single organisation's membership base.

Primary research

Quantitative research

The quantitative component comprised a survey of 206 respondents across 14 African countries. The respondents represented women at different career stages: students and recent graduates, early-career professionals, mid-career and senior professionals, founders and entrepreneurs.

The survey covered pathways into technology, motivations for entering the sector, barriers to entry, career progression, compensation, workplace culture, psychological safety, burnout, flexibility, mentorship, leadership, entrepreneurship, access to capital, ecosystem support, professional development, artificial intelligence adoption and expectations for the future of work.

Unless otherwise stated, percentages presented in this report are based on the 206 survey responses.

Qualitative research

The quantitative findings were complemented by qualitative interviews with women and professionals working across different parts of the technology ecosystem. These conversations provided greater context on the experiences behind the survey findings, particularly around career progression, workplace experiences, visibility, mentorship and sponsorship, meaningful responsibility, professional development, entrepreneurship and the changing nature of work.

Participants included technology professionals, product and technical practitioners, marketing and growth professionals, and HR and ecosystem leaders, reflecting varied pathways into technology - including transitions from non-technical academic backgrounds, self-directed learning, community-led development, internships and movement between functions as careers developed.



The qualitative material is incorporated throughout the report alongside relevant quantitative findings, using individual perspectives to illustrate how broader dynamics such as credibility, visibility, career ownership, sponsorship, workplace flexibility, practical learning and access to opportunity are experienced in practice. These interviews are not intended to provide statistically representative findings; they provide individual perspectives that add context to the patterns identified through the survey.

Secondary research

Secondary research situates these findings within the wider context of Africa's digital economy and technology ecosystem, drawing on research and publications from institutions including the International Telecommunication Union (ITU), the African Development Bank (AfDB), the World Bank, GSMA, Partech Africa and McKinsey. These sources provide evidence on digital access and connectivity, digital skills and employment, technology investment, the growth of Africa's digital economy, gender gaps in tech participation, women's representation in leadership and entrepreneurship, and developments shaping the future of work.



CHAPTER ONE

Africa's Digital Economy and the Case for Gender Inclusion

The scale of Africa's digital economy, the technology ecosystem taking shape around it, and the place of women within it.

Africa's technology economy is entering a more consequential phase. Digital services are becoming increasingly embedded in financial services, commerce, healthcare, agriculture, education and public services, while mobile connectivity remains one of the continent's most important routes into the digital economy. In 2025, mobile technologies and services contributed US\$240 billion to Africa's economy, equivalent to 7.8% of continental gross domestic product (GDP), and supported approximately 13 million jobs. The GSMA projects that this contribution will reach US\$290 billion by 2030, driven by continued expansion in connectivity, digital services, 5G and artificial intelligence (AI). [1]

CHAPTER ONE IN NUMBERS

US\$240bn contributed to Africa's economy by mobile technologies in 2025	36% of Africa's population was using the internet in 2025 (74% globally)
230m jobs expected to require digital skills by 2030	31% vs 40% internet use among women compared with men in Africa

The scale of that contribution sits alongside a considerable access gap. Only 36% of Africa's population was using the internet in 2025, compared with 74% globally. The difference within the continent is equally important: internet use stood at 55% among urban populations but just 21% among rural populations. Women also remain less connected than men, with 31% of women using the internet compared with 40% of men. [2]

Africa is therefore building its digital economy while still working through the conditions required for people to participate in it at scale. Affordability, devices, digital skills, infrastructure and relevant digital services all shape who can benefit from the opportunities being created.

The workforce implications are substantial. The African Development Bank estimates that approximately 230 million jobs across the continent will require some level of digital skills by 2030, while the World Bank's research shows that much of this demand will come from occupations outside the traditional technology sector as businesses across agriculture, manufacturing and services adopt digital tools. [3][4]



That makes the digital economy more than a technology-sector story. It is becoming part of the wider labour market, and the people who have access to the skills and opportunities created by that shift will have an increasing role in Africa's economic future.

The African tech ecosystem is growing

The startup ecosystem offers another view of the continent's technology development. After two years of declining venture activity, African tech funding recovered in 2025, with startups raising US\$4.1 billion in combined equity and debt funding across 570 transactions. Total funding increased 25% from the previous year, although the recovery was driven substantially by debt: debt funding reached US\$1.64 billion, while equity funding grew more modestly to US\$2.41 billion. [5]

Capital remains concentrated in a small number of markets. Kenya, South Africa, Egypt and Nigeria accounted for 72% of total African tech funding in 2025, reinforcing the strength of the continent's established technology hubs.

MARKET	2025 FUNDING RAISED
Kenya	US\$1.04 billion
South Africa	US\$715 million
Egypt	US\$604 million
Nigeria	US\$572 million
Share of all African tech funding	72% combined

The sector mix is also beginning to broaden. Fintech remains the largest equity-funded sector, but 2025 saw stronger investment in areas such as cleantech, healthtech and enterprise technology. Partech recorded US\$550 million in cleantech equity funding, US\$215 million in healthtech and US\$238 million in enterprise technology, with each of these sectors exceeding US\$200 million for the first time since the 2021–22 funding period. [5]

That expansion matters for the workforce as well as for founders and investors. As technology becomes more deeply integrated into sectors that were previously considered outside the traditional tech industry, the range of roles and skills required to participate in the digital economy is also widening.

The ecosystem itself has become part of the infrastructure supporting that participation. Innovation hubs, accelerators, universities, professional networks and technology communities create different routes into skills, employment, entrepreneurship and investment. For many people entering the industry, particularly those without established professional networks, these institutions can determine how easily they find their first opportunity and what happens afterwards.



The gender gap starts before the workplace

Women face barriers to participation well before questions of promotion or leadership arise. In Sub-Saharan Africa, women were 26% less likely than men to use mobile internet in 2025, leaving an estimated 226 million women in the region without mobile internet access. GSMA identifies affordability, access to devices, digital skills and other barriers as factors behind the continuing gap. [6]

The gap becomes more visible as women move through the technology pipeline. McKinsey's 2025 analysis found that women account for 47% of STEM graduates from African universities, but represent only around 23% to 30% of technology roles. At senior levels, the numbers fall further: fewer than one in five publicly listed African companies with C-suite technology roles had a woman in that position. [7]

Capital tells a similar story. Women-founded companies accounted for 19% of equity deals in 2025 but received only 10% of equity funding, according to Partech. [5]

STAGE OF THE PIPELINE	WOMEN'S SHARE
STEM graduates from African universities	47%
Technology roles across the workforce	23–30%
C-suite technology roles (listed companies)	Fewer than 1 in 5
Share of equity deals (2025)	19%
Share of equity funding value (2025)	10%

There is therefore a visible difference between women's presence in the pipeline and their representation at the points where influence, capital and decision-making are concentrated.

The current state of women in African tech

The picture of women in African technology is more nuanced than a simple story of underrepresentation. Women are already present across the education pipeline, technology workforce and entrepreneurial ecosystem. McKinsey's research puts women's share of STEM graduates at 47%, while its analysis of the technology workforce places women's representation at between 23% and 30%. [7] The challenge is the movement between those stages, and what happens once women arrive.

The gender digital divide remains significant across the continent: the ITU estimates that 31% of women in Africa used the internet in 2025, compared with 40% of men. The gap is also shaped by geography, with internet use among rural Africans standing at 21% compared with 55% among urban populations.

The same unevenness appears in entrepreneurship. Women-founded companies are participating in the technology investment market, but their share of funding remains considerably smaller than their share of deals. In 2025, female-founded startups received 10% of African equity funding,



despite accounting for 19% of equity transactions. At the leadership level, the gap becomes wider still. The limited representation of women in C-suite technology roles shows that being present in the workforce does not automatically translate into decision-making authority.

These patterns also vary considerably across the continent. Africa is not one technology market, and the conditions surrounding a woman's career differ according to country, access to infrastructure, education, income, industry and proximity to established technology ecosystems. The concentration of venture funding in four major markets is one example of how unevenly opportunity is distributed.

Why this matters now

Africa is entering the next phase of its digital transformation with a technology economy that is larger, more diverse and more deeply connected to everyday economic activity than it was a decade ago. Mobile technologies already contribute US\$240 billion to the continent's economy. Venture funding has returned to growth, although capital remains concentrated in a handful of markets. Demand for digital skills is expected to rise substantially as technology spreads across sectors, while AI is beginning to influence how businesses operate and how people work.

Governments are also setting clearer targets around the digital economy. The African Union's Digital Transformation Strategy sets a continental ambition for an inclusive digital economy by 2030, while recent regional commitments have placed digital skills, digital jobs, AI capacity, connectivity and women's participation within the wider development agenda. [8] In November 2025, ministers from West and Central Africa adopted the Cotonou Declaration, committing to stronger digital infrastructure, digital skills, innovation ecosystems and opportunities for women and young people as part of the region's 2030 digital transformation agenda. [9]

Against that backdrop, understanding women's position in the technology economy becomes increasingly important. The issue is no longer limited to whether women are entering the sector. It extends to the quality of the opportunities available to them, their ability to progress, their access to capital and leadership, and their place in an industry being reshaped by AI and other emerging technologies. This is where the research moves from the wider ecosystem to the women working within it.



CHAPTER TWO

The Case for Gender Inclusion in Africa's Digital Economy

Why looking beyond headline participation numbers is critical to understanding the real position of women building Africa's digital future.

Africa's technology ecosystem has grown far beyond the startup sector it was once largely associated with. Digital infrastructure now sits within many of the systems that keep economies running, from banking and payments to logistics, healthcare, agriculture, commerce and retail. As digital tools become more embedded in how businesses operate and how people access services, the definition of what constitutes a "tech career" is expanding with it.

Technology is no longer confined to software startups. A professional working on payment reconciliation at a commercial bank, managing clinical data systems within a hospital network, or using technology to improve customer logistics for an e-commerce business is also contributing to the digital economy. The same is true of the product managers, marketers, operations professionals, analysts, designers and other specialists whose work increasingly depends on technology.

This wider reach has created more ways for people to participate in the sector, and women are taking up many of those opportunities. They are founding businesses, building technical products, working across technology-enabled industries, and creating communities and programmes that help others develop the skills to enter the field every year.

But a larger technology economy does not automatically mean a more inclusive one. A rapidly growing digital sector can generate jobs, launch companies and attract venture capital without distributing those economic gains equitably. For women across Africa, the central question in 2026 is no longer whether they are present in the technology ecosystem. The substantive inquiry is where they are participating, how they got there, the daily workplace friction they navigate, and the systemic ceilings that dictate how far they can rise.

KEY FINDINGS

53.4%

entered tech through grassroots communities or self-directed learning, bypassing traditional computer science degrees

61.2%

entered out of genuine curiosity and passion for technology rather than short-term income

71.0%

sit within their first five years in the sector

48.5%

cite a lack of mentorship as their primary barrier to entry; 39.8% cite the first job or internship



Technology as economic infrastructure

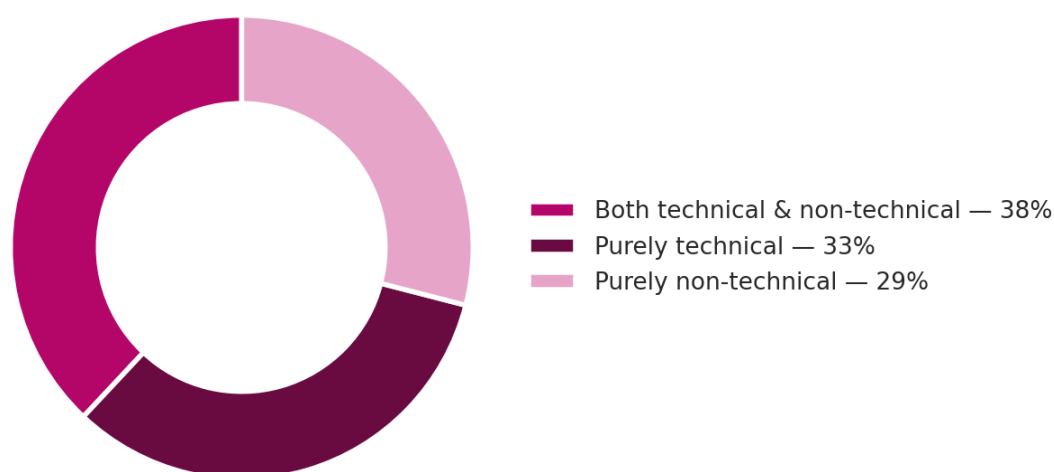
The ongoing digitalisation of the African economy has dismantled traditional industry boundaries. In banking, payment infrastructure and mobile money have fundamentally altered how businesses transact. In healthcare, telemedicine and digitised inventory management have extended reach to underserved populations. Enterprise platforms, logistics trackers and cloud infrastructure now dictate how small businesses manage inventory, communicate with vendors and receive payments across borders.

As this happens, the distinction between a “tech company” and a company that uses technology becomes less useful when looking at the workforce. An engineer or product specialist does not need to sit inside a venture-backed tech company to drive technical output. She may be optimising checkout funnels for a direct-to-consumer brand, or managing customer relationship architectures inside a consulting firm.

Because technical skill sets are distributed across sectors, our evaluation of female inclusion must account for this breadth. Looking solely at traditional software engineering departments inside pure-play tech companies misses where a substantial portion of African women apply their skills every day.

Our survey reflects this wider participation. Tech is the largest industry represented, accounting for 27.7% of respondents, though women also reported working across non-profit, healthcare, financial services, education, media, consulting, agriculture, telecommunications, government and other sectors. By role type, 38% of respondents work across both technical and non-technical functions, 33% hold purely technical roles and 29% hold purely non-technical roles, underscoring that hybrid skill sets - not narrow specialisation - define the modern female tech workforce.

FIGURE 2.1 - CURRENT ROLE TYPE



Base: 206 respondents. Hybrid roles are the single largest group.

This distribution gives us a broader way of thinking about women’s participation in tech. Technical expertise remains important, but the digital economy also depends on people working across

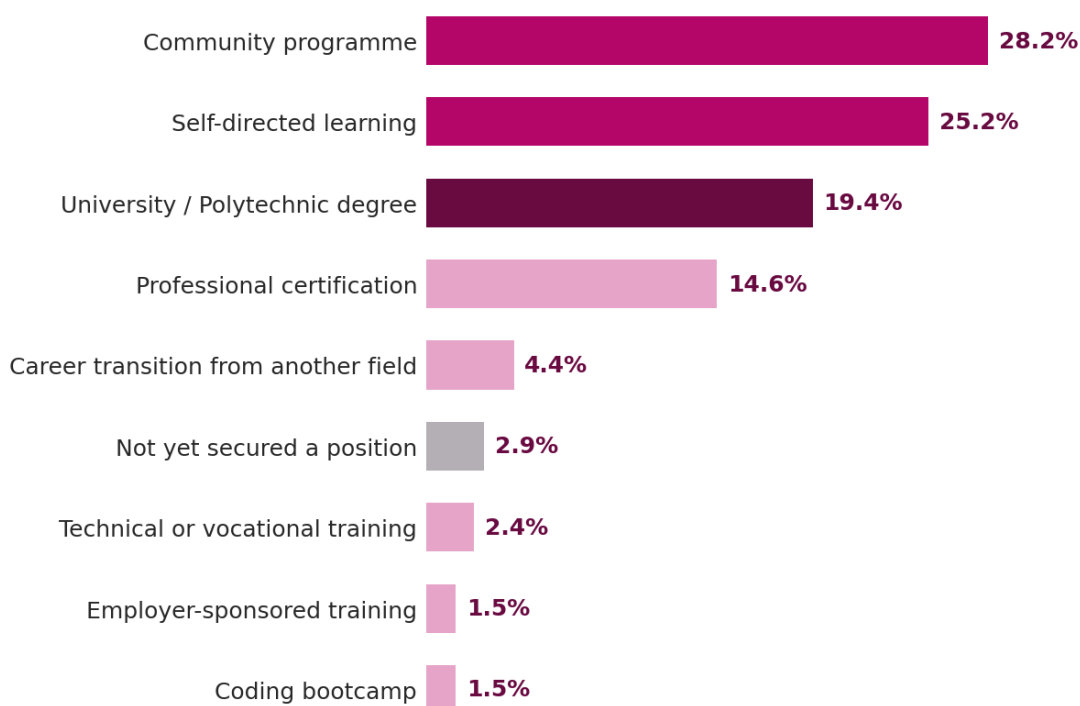


product, operations, communications, marketing, research, finance and other functions that connect technology to users and businesses.

The alternative gateways to entry

The path into tech is rarely as linear as it is often presented. Formal education is one route, but our data shows it is far from the primary one: community programmes were the most commonly reported entry pathway (28.2%), followed closely by self-directed learning (25.2%), together accounting for over half of all respondents. University or polytechnic degrees followed at 19.4%, with professional certifications at 14.6%.

FIGURE 2.2 - HOW WOMEN ENTERED THE TECHNOLOGY SECTOR



The ordering itself is the finding: community-driven and self-taught pathways outpace traditional degree routes combined, pointing to an ecosystem where structured community institutions are doing more entry-level work than universities are.

Grassroots tech communities across Africa are no longer merely casual networking groups; they serve as the de facto educational infrastructure of the continent's digital sector. They design curricula, run technical cohorts, provide peer accountability and supply the scaffolding that traditional academic institutions have failed to deliver. However, this reality also highlights a clear vulnerability: talent acquisition relies almost entirely on personal resilience and donor-funded community programmes, while systemic support from formal institutions and corporate employers remains noticeably absent.



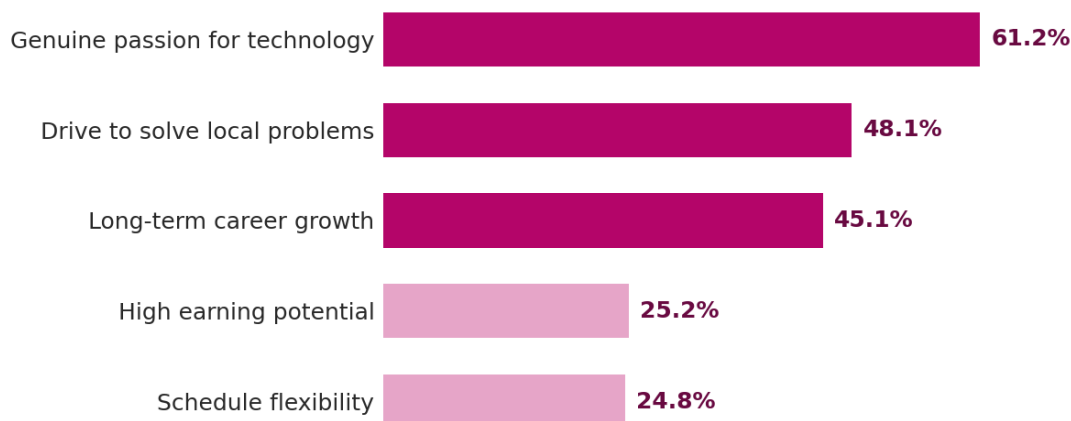
"Organisations need to also be connected to and partner with programmes developing female tech talent, like what you're doing at She Code Africa, to leverage existing talent pools that are already being developed, rather than trying to build the pipeline from scratch."

- Seyifunmi Oderinde, HR

Interest is driving entry, but access shapes the journey

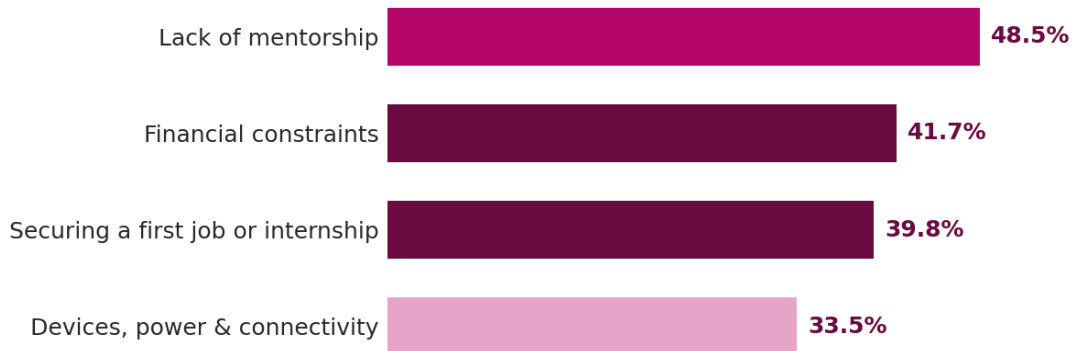
The decision to pursue a career in technology is driven primarily by intrinsic motivation, not external incentive. Asked what led them into the industry, women pointed first to intellectual interest: 61.2% cited genuine passion for technology, 48.1% cited a drive to solve local problems and 45.1% cited structured opportunities for long-term career growth. Financial factors ranked lower - high earning potential (25.2%) and schedule flexibility (24.8%) - suggesting this talent pool is oriented toward building careers, not chasing quick or temporary roles.

FIGURE 2.3 - MOTIVATIONS FOR ENTERING TECHNOLOGY



Yet ambition alone does not translate into functional careers. At the entry level, women face four compounding barriers.

- **Mentorship gaps:** 48.5% identified lack of mentorship as a major challenge to entering the industry.
- **Financial barriers:** 41.7% cited financial constraints as an obstacle to acquiring skills.
- **Access to first opportunities:** 39.8% struggled to secure a first job or internship - the critical bottleneck between learning and employment.
- **Infrastructure challenges:** 33.5% cited unreliable access to devices, electricity or affordable internet.

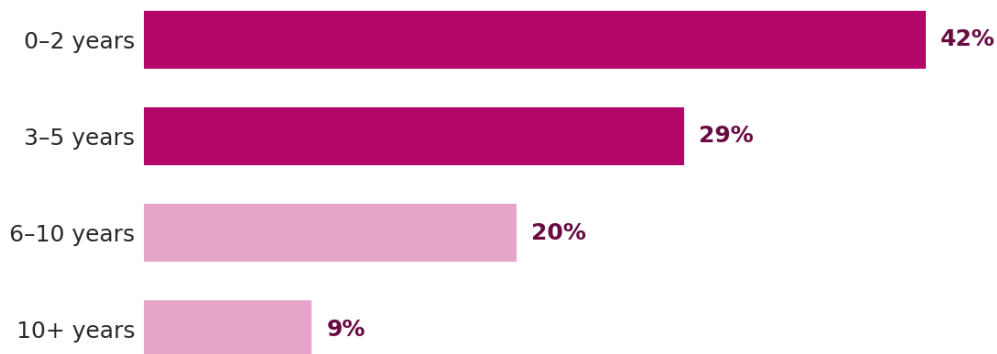
**FIGURE 2.4 - PRIMARY BARRIERS TO ENTERING THE SECTOR**

That mentorship outranks financial constraint is the sharper finding here. It implies the primary bottleneck for women entering tech is not capital but access to guidance - a structural gap, not a resourcing one.

This has direct design implications: interventions built primarily around funding (scholarships, device grants, data stipends) will under-serve the largest reported barrier. Programmes that pair structured mentorship with financial support, rather than treating them as separate tracks, are better positioned to address entry-level attrition, since the two barriers likely compound rather than operate independently. A woman without a mentor is also less likely to know which certifications or roles are worth the financial investment in the first place.

A young workforce is entering the sector

The women represented in this research are predominantly young and early in their careers. Over 91% of respondents are under 35: 32% are between 18 and 24, and 59% are between 25 and 34. Career-stage data follows the same pattern - 42% have zero to two years of experience and 29% have three to five years. In other words, 71% of respondents are within their first five years in tech.

FIGURE 2.5 - YEARS OF EXPERIENCE IN TECHNOLOGY



This places the majority of the sample at a formative point in their professional lives: still developing technical and professional expertise, building networks, finding mentors and working out what progression looks like for them.

What happens during these years is disproportionately consequential. This is not simply a workforce that is young; it is a workforce concentrated at the exact career stage where retention decisions are made. If these early years are characterised by stagnant pay, pervasive burnout, uncredited responsibility and absent career paths, the ecosystem risks losing its future mid-to-senior talent pool before it has had the chance to form - not through a single dramatic exit, but through steady attrition to other industries or international migration.

The stakes compound over time: talent lost at year three does not just remove one person from the pipeline, it removes a future mentor, team lead or founder from the next cohort's pathway in. The experiences women have in the workplace today will shape not only whether they personally remain and progress into leadership, but whether the ecosystem produces the senior women who make the next generation's entry, mentorship and advancement possible at all.

Beyond entry: what this report examines

Getting women into tech is only one part of understanding their position in the sector. The more useful picture emerges when we follow the journey beyond entry: what happens at work, how careers develop, who gets opportunities to lead, what support is available, and how women are preparing for change in technology itself.

This report therefore moves beyond participation to examine the experiences and decisions that shape women's careers over time - where they are in the ecosystem today, how they are progressing, the barriers they encounter, the support available to them and the opportunities they see ahead. Africa's digital economy will continue to change, and women will shape that change as much as they are shaped by it.



CHAPTER THREE

Experience: What Is It Like to Build a Career in African Tech?

What happens after women enter the sector, and what shapes their ability to grow and stay.

Entering the tech space does not guarantee a clear path forward. Once inside the sector, women's experiences are shaped by the opportunities available to them, how their work is recognised, what they earn, the support they receive and how they manage the demands of an industry in constant flux.

The picture is mixed. Some women are finding supportive workplaces, flexibility and room to contribute their ideas; others are encountering limited progression, pay dissatisfaction and a lack of mentorship. The pressure to keep learning is also taking a toll - many respondents identify continuous upskilling itself as a source of burnout.

KEY METRICS

68.0% earn less than US\$5,000 annually from their technology work	42.8% report no career progression, or added responsibilities without a promotion
52.4% do not currently have a mentor but would like one	46.6% identify the pressure to constantly learn new skills as a source of burnout
47.0% are satisfied with their work flexibility - the highest-rated dimension measured	9.3% are satisfied with their salary and benefits - the lowest-rated dimension

Read individually, these figures describe separate frustrations. Read together, they describe one mechanism: the mentorship gap identified at entry (48.5%) does not close once women are in the sector - it persists at 52.4% mid-career, and it now compounds with two additional pressures. Without a mentor to advocate for their advancement or benchmark their value, women are more likely to remain undercompensated (68.0% under US\$5,000) and to absorb added responsibility without promotion (42.8%), because there is no one positioned to name the gap between their output and their title. Absent that structural support, the burden of managing a career shifts entirely onto the individual, which is also why 46.6% experience the pressure to self-upskill as burnout rather than growth: it is unguided effort, not a mentored trajectory.

The result is a mid-career workforce carrying senior-level output at entry-level pay, with no structural mechanism - mentorship, sponsorship or transparent progression criteria - converting

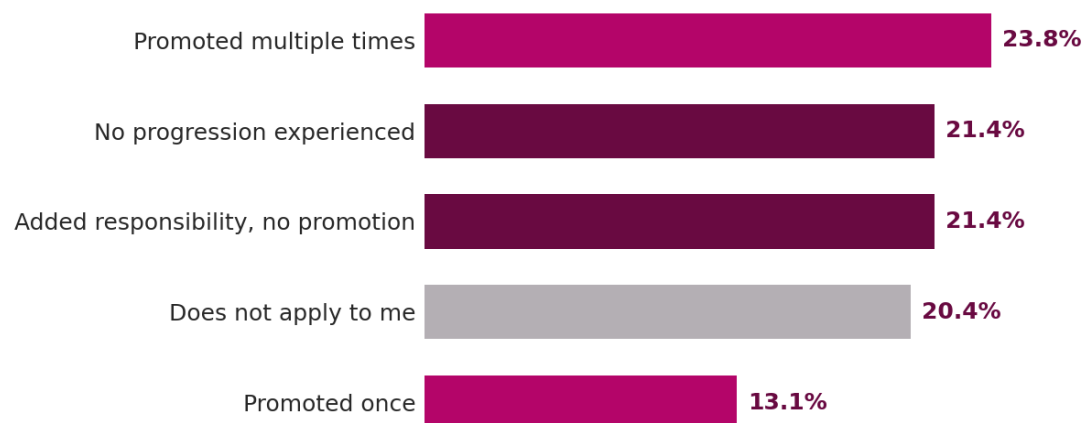


their tenure into advancement. This is the same access gap identified in the entry-level data, now compounded by three additional years of unrewarded output.

Promotions and the reality of uncredited responsibility

Career progression looks different across the women surveyed. Some are moving into new roles and taking on greater responsibility, while others report little formal movement. 23.8% have received multiple promotions and 13.1% have been promoted once. At the same time, 21.4% report no career progression at all, and another 21.4% have taken on additional responsibility without a corresponding promotion - meaning progression stalls for 42.8% of respondents in one form or another.

FIGURE 3.1 - CAREER PROGRESSION EXPERIENCED TO DATE



This pattern of uncredited responsibility, often referred to as shadow work, is common across early-stage startups and lean corporate teams. Taking on more responsibility can be part of growing into a role, but when it is not accompanied by a change in title, compensation or formal recognition, the path to progression becomes harder to see and harder to claim.

"Things like organising, documenting, coordinating people, taking notes or helping everyone else get organised. Those things are useful, but if you're always doing them while someone else is getting the opportunity to lead the actual project, it can affect your progression."

- Mariam Salami, Full Stack Developer

Mariam's account points to a specific mechanism, not just a general complaint: the work that keeps teams functioning - coordination, documentation, organisation - is real labour, but it is rarely the labour that gets someone put forward to lead. When that split holds consistently, the same women doing the most operational work are structurally the least likely to be positioned for the next promotion.

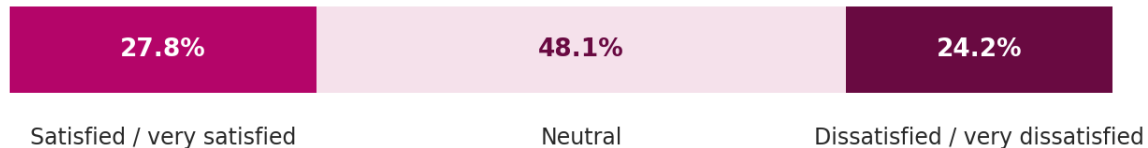
This uncertainty shows up in how respondents assess their own trajectory. 25.7% say they are progressing faster than expected, almost matched by 23.3% who say they are progressing more



slowly, while 28.1% either feel it is too early to tell or are unsure where their careers are headed - over half the sample without a confident read on their own progression.

That uncertainty sharpens when respondents assess the opportunities available to them. Only 27.8% are satisfied with their career progression opportunities and 24.2% are dissatisfied, but the largest group by far, 48.1%, is neutral.

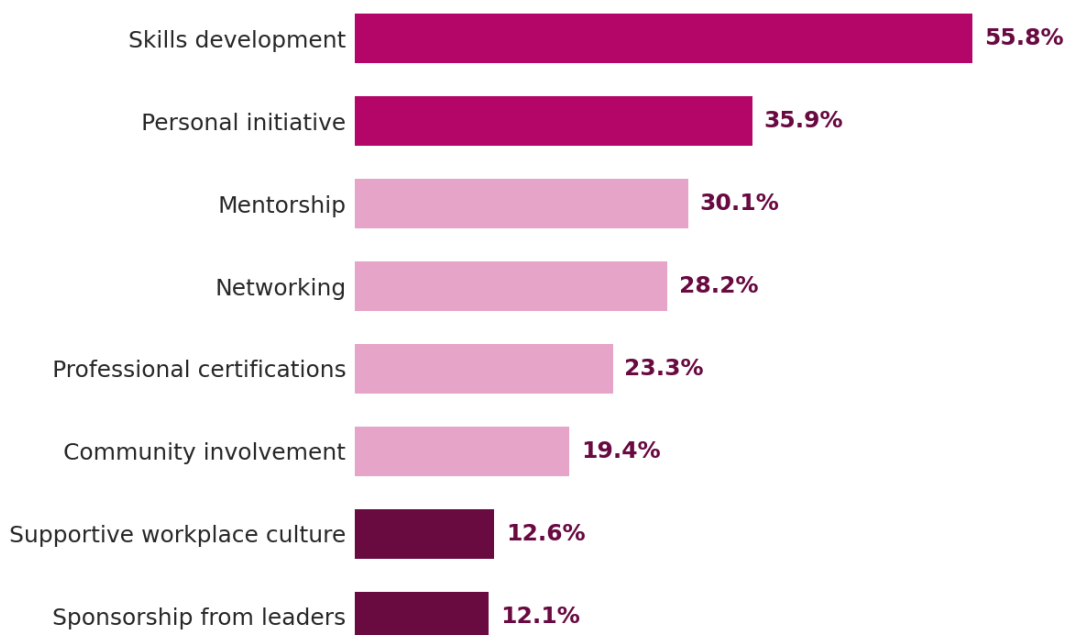
FIGURE 3.2 - SATISFACTION WITH CAREER PROGRESSION OPPORTUNITIES



Neutrality at this scale is itself a finding: it suggests that for many women the problem is not a visibly blocked path, but an invisible one - progression criteria vague enough that even the people subject to them cannot say with confidence whether they are advancing or standing still. Uncredited responsibility, in this light, is not a separate issue from unclear progression; it is a likely cause of it. When the criteria for advancement are undefined, informal contribution has no mechanism to convert into formal credit.

What is driving career growth?

Technical skills are the strongest factor women associate with their own career growth: 55.8% identify skills development as a key contributor, followed by personal initiative at 35.9%. But skills and effort are only part of the picture. Mentorship (30.1%) and networking (28.2%) also feature prominently, suggesting that progression depends not only on what women can do, but on the relationships and guidance available to them. Professional certifications follow at 23.3% and community involvement at 19.4%. Institutional factors sit at the bottom of the list: only 12.6% credit a supportive workplace culture and just 12.1% point to sponsorship from leaders.

**FIGURE 3.3 - FACTORS WOMEN CREDIT FOR THEIR OWN CAREER GROWTH**

Magenta: individual effort. Plum: institutional support.

That ordering is the finding. The two highest-ranked factors - skills and initiative - are things women build alone. The two lowest-ranked - culture and sponsorship - are things organisations are responsible for providing. Read as a hierarchy, it says career growth in this sector is currently driven almost entirely by individual effort, with institutional support acting as a marginal factor rather than a structural one. That is not evidence of low ambition but evidence of a system where the burden of progression has been placed on the individual by default, because the institutional mechanisms that should share that burden - sponsorship, culture, structured mentorship - are not functioning at scale.

The demand for mentorship is already there. What is missing is supply.

Compensation: what women earn

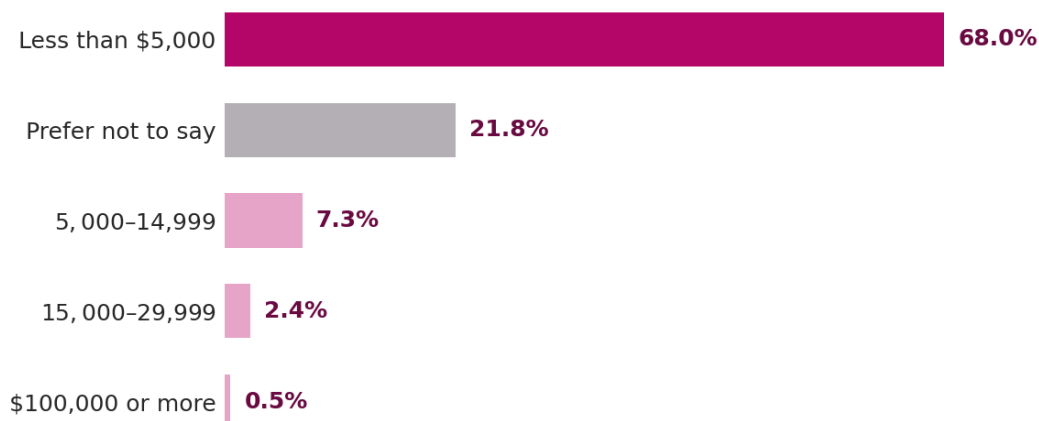
Building a career is not only about progression or the work itself. Compensation also shapes how women experience their careers, particularly when they are trying to understand whether their work is being valued fairly.

The salary picture in this survey is heavily concentrated at the lower end. More than two-thirds of respondents (68.0%) report an annual income of less than US\$5,000 from their technology work. A further 7.3% earn between US\$5,000 and US\$14,999, and 2.4% earn between US\$15,000 and



US\$29,999. Only 0.5% report earning US\$100,000 or more, while 21.8% preferred not to disclose their income.

FIGURE 3.4 - ANNUAL INCOME FROM TECHNOLOGY WORK



Base: 206 respondents.

The profile of the respondents is important when reading these figures. 71% are within their first five years of a technology career, so this income data largely reflects women still early in their professional journeys. But for those earning under US\$5,000 a year, the figure also has to be read against the economic realities of many African markets. In countries such as Nigeria, Kenya and Ghana, currency devaluation and inflation have put sustained pressure on the value of local earnings. At roughly US\$400 a month or less, income is quickly absorbed by everyday expenses, including housing, transport, data and internet access, and the cost of maintaining reliable power - meaning the real purchasing power behind these numbers is lower than the dollar figure suggests.

Against this backdrop, it is unsurprising that salary and benefits receive the lowest satisfaction rating of any workplace dimension measured in the survey. Only 9.3% of respondents are satisfied or very satisfied with their salary and benefits, while 41.8% are dissatisfied or very dissatisfied. The largest group, 48.5%, is neutral.

That dissatisfaction is closely tied to a second, quieter issue: many women are not sure whether their pay is fair to begin with. 42.2% of respondents are unsure whether they are paid fairly compared with male colleagues of similar skill and experience. Another 22.0% believe they are paid less fairly, while 24.8% believe they are paid fairly.

**FIGURE 3.5 - PERCEIVED PAY FAIRNESS RELATIVE TO MALE COLLEAGUES**

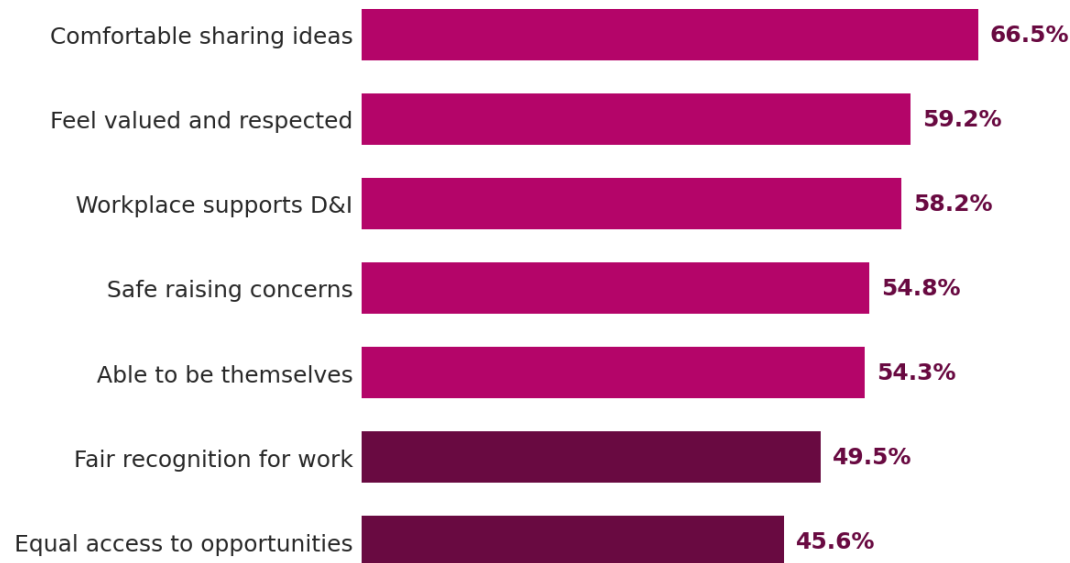
The 42.2% figure is the one worth sitting with. It is larger than either group with a firm opinion - larger than those who believe they are underpaid, and larger than those who believe they are paid fairly. That is not neutrality in the way the satisfaction-neutral figure above might read; it is an absence of the information required to hold a position at all. Without visibility into salary bands, level-based pay expectations, or how compensation is meant to shift as responsibility grows, women are not withholding judgment - they lack the reference points to make one.

This is the same structural gap identified earlier in the report, now showing up in compensation: informal, undocumented systems do not just slow career progression, they make it impossible for women to know if they are being paid what the work is worth. Being unhappy with your pay is one thing. Not knowing what fair pay would even look like is another - and it is the second problem, not the first, that 42.2% of this sample is actually facing.

42.2% of the women surveyed do not know whether they are underpaid, because no one has told them what fair looks like.

Workplace culture

The experience at work is more positive when respondents talk about their immediate workplace environment. A solid majority report positive interpersonal dynamics within their immediate teams. Two-thirds (66.5%) feel comfortable sharing their ideas and opinions at work, and 59.2% feel valued and respected. More than half also believe their organisations support diversity and inclusion (58.2%), feel safe raising concerns or challenges (54.8%) and feel able to be themselves at work (54.3%).

**FIGURE 3.6 - WORKPLACE CULTURE AND PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY**

Magenta: belonging measures. Plum: conversion measures - recognition and access.

The picture becomes less positive when the focus shifts from how women experience their immediate working environment to how they experience recognition and opportunity within it. Less than half - 49.5% - believe their contributions are recognised fairly, and only 45.6% believe they have equal access to opportunities.

That gap is the finding, not just the two numbers on their own. Every metric at the top of the chart is about belonging: feeling heard, safe and able to be yourself. Every metric at the bottom is about conversion: whether that belonging translates into something material - recognition, access, opportunity. The drop from 66.5% comfort to 45.6% equal access is roughly 21 points, and it maps precisely onto the pattern already established in this report. Workplaces are doing the interpersonal work of inclusion - psychological safety, day-to-day respect - without doing the structural work of converting that inclusion into recognition and advancement. A team can feel warm and still be procedurally unfair, because warmth does not require anyone to change how promotions, credit or opportunity are actually allocated.

Two accounts point to different costs of that gap. The first describes the cognitive tax of being the only woman in the room - a form of ongoing self-monitoring that has nothing to do with the work itself.

"There have been meetings where I was the only woman on the technical team, and you become very aware of yourself. You think about whether you're speaking enough, whether you're speaking too much, whether people are actually listening to you."

- Mariam Salami, Full Stack Developer

The second describes the adaptive response many women develop in reaction to that tax: learning to compress or soften expertise so it reads as less threatening.



"For me, one of the biggest lessons has been learning not to shrink my expertise just to make other people comfortable. If you know what you're doing, you should be able to communicate that confidently."

- Onyeka Nnabugwu

Read together, the accounts explain the chart's drop-off better than the numbers alone do: if women are managing how much space they take up in the room, they are also, by extension, less likely to be the ones whose contributions get noticed, credited and rewarded. The belonging metrics measure whether the room feels safe. The recognition metrics measure whether speaking up in that room actually pays off. This data suggests African tech workplaces have made real progress on the first and comparatively little on the second.

The burnout drivers

Working in technology comes with an expectation of staying current. New tools, platforms and ways of working continue to emerge, and professionals are expected to keep pace. For many of the women surveyed, however, that pressure to keep learning is also becoming part of what makes work exhausting.

46.6% of respondents identify the pressure to constantly learn new skills as a contributor to burnout - the most frequently cited factor in the survey. Heavy workloads follow at 39.8% and long working hours at 37.4%. Poor work-life balance (33.0%) and lack of support from teams or managers (32.0%) are also significant contributors.

FIGURE 3.7 - PRIMARY CAUSES OF WORKPLACE BURNOUT





The finding adds another dimension to the conversation around professional development. Learning new skills can drive career growth, but the expectation to continually learn is also becoming another demand on people's time and energy - and the top-ranked burnout driver in this survey is not workload or hours, it is the open-ended obligation to keep up.

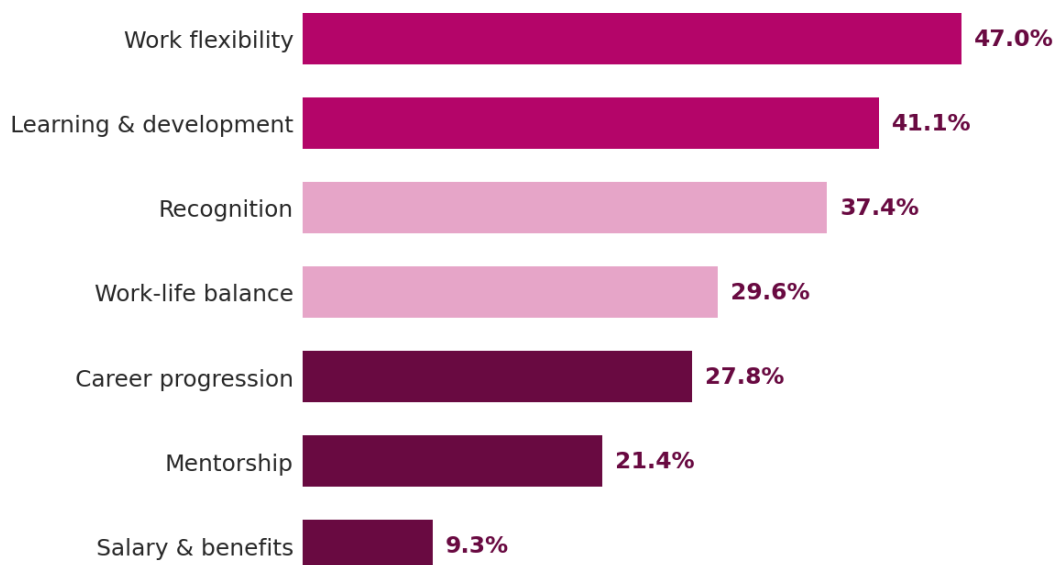
The other leading causes of burnout reinforce this. Heavy workloads and long working hours point to the demands of the job itself, while poor work-life balance and limited support add to the pressure. Job insecurity, cited by 26.2%, is another reminder that for some women the pressure is not only about doing well in their current roles but also about staying relevant enough to remain employable.

Taken together, these figures describe a structural tension rather than five separate stressors: the same industry that offers opportunities for growth also demands continuous, unsupported adaptation to stay eligible for those opportunities. For women already navigating questions of progression, pay and access to support, that expectation raises the cost of simply staying in the field.

The pressures of staying

The pressures of technology work do not exist in isolation. Some aspects of the working environment can make those demands easier to manage, and flexibility stands out: 47.0% of respondents are satisfied with their work flexibility, making it the highest-rated aspect of professional life measured in the survey. That satisfaction does not extend to work-life balance. Only 29.6% are satisfied with their work-life balance, while 26.2% are dissatisfied. The difference suggests that having flexibility in where or when work happens does not, on its own, reduce the wider pressures of the job.

FIGURE 3.8 - OVERALL JOB SATISFACTION BENCHMARK



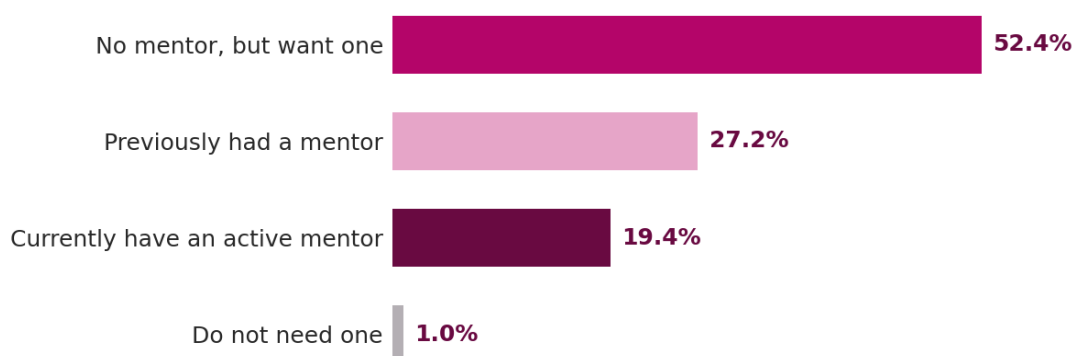
Share of respondents satisfied or very satisfied with each dimension.



Read as a ranked list rather than seven isolated figures, this benchmark tells its own story: satisfaction is highest for the aspects of work an individual can control or absorb personally (flexibility, self-directed learning) and lowest for the aspects that require institutional infrastructure to deliver (mentorship, salary structure). That is the same individual-versus-institutional split identified earlier in the report's career-growth data, now showing up again as a satisfaction gradient.

Mentorship is where that gap is starkest. 52.4% of respondents do not currently have a mentor but would like one. A further 27.2% previously had a mentor and 19.4% currently have one active. Only 1.0% say they do not need one.

FIGURE 3.9 - MENTORSHIP ACCESS ACROSS THE WORKFORCE



This is particularly striking given that 30.1% of respondents identified mentorship as a direct contributor to their own career growth. Demand for mentorship is not a soft preference but a documented driver of the outcome women say they want - progression - and yet only 19.4% currently have it.

For women navigating a changing industry, flexibility and mentorship serve different functions in a career: flexibility determines how work fits around a life, while mentorship determines how well-informed someone's career decisions are - what to take on, when to push for more, when to move. This survey shows African tech workplaces have solved reasonably well for the first and left the second almost entirely to chance.

"Mentorship is useful, but sponsorship is even more powerful. Having someone who will actually recommend you for an opportunity, put your name forward, or trust you with a bigger responsibility can completely change someone's career trajectory."

- Onyeka Nnabugwu

That distinction matters for how this report's recommendations should be scoped. If the mentorship gap (52.4%) is a guidance problem, the fix is pairing programmes and structured coaching. But this is describing something further downstream: advocacy, not advice. A mentor can tell a woman what she needs to do; only a sponsor can put her name in the room where the decision gets made. Given how consistently this report has found strong individual effort (55.8% cite skills, 35.9% cite initiative) failing to convert into institutional outcomes (12.1% cite sponsorship, 45.6% report equal



access to opportunity), sponsorship - not mentorship alone - may be the more precise lever for closing the gap between what women are doing and what they are getting credited for.



CHAPTER FOUR

Progression: Who Gets to Lead, Build and Influence?

Moving beyond participation to examine leadership, decision-making, entrepreneurship, visibility and influence.

Getting into technology is only the first part of the journey. What happens after entry matters just as much: whether women are able to take on greater responsibility, move into leadership, build businesses, influence decisions and gain the visibility that comes with experience.

For the 206 women surveyed for this report, the picture is mixed. There is clear ambition and a strong expectation of career progression, but that expectation sits alongside a relatively small share of women currently in formal leadership positions. Almost half of respondents, 49.5%, do not currently hold a leadership position. At the same time, 76.7% are confident or extremely confident that they will reach senior leadership within the next five years.

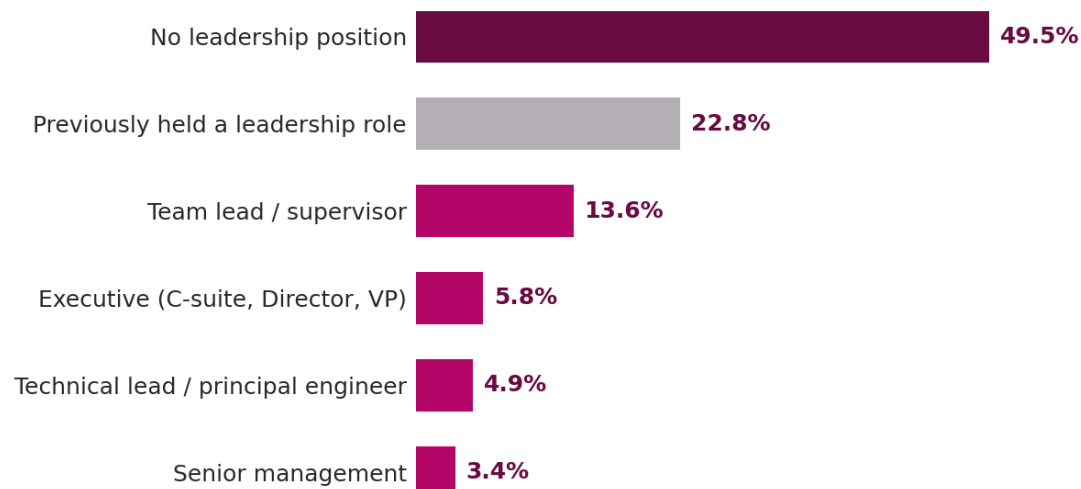
KEY METRICS

49.5% do not currently hold a leadership position	76.7% are confident they can reach senior leadership within five years
40.3% intend to build a tech-enabled business or product	43.6% identify funding as the biggest challenge to building a sustainable business

That gap between where women are today and where they expect to be is the chapter's central question. It raises questions about the opportunities available to women as they move through their careers, the extent of their decision-making authority, and the support they have to pursue leadership or build something of their own. This chapter looks at that progression from several angles: leadership within organisations, influence over decisions, entrepreneurship, visibility and participation in governance.

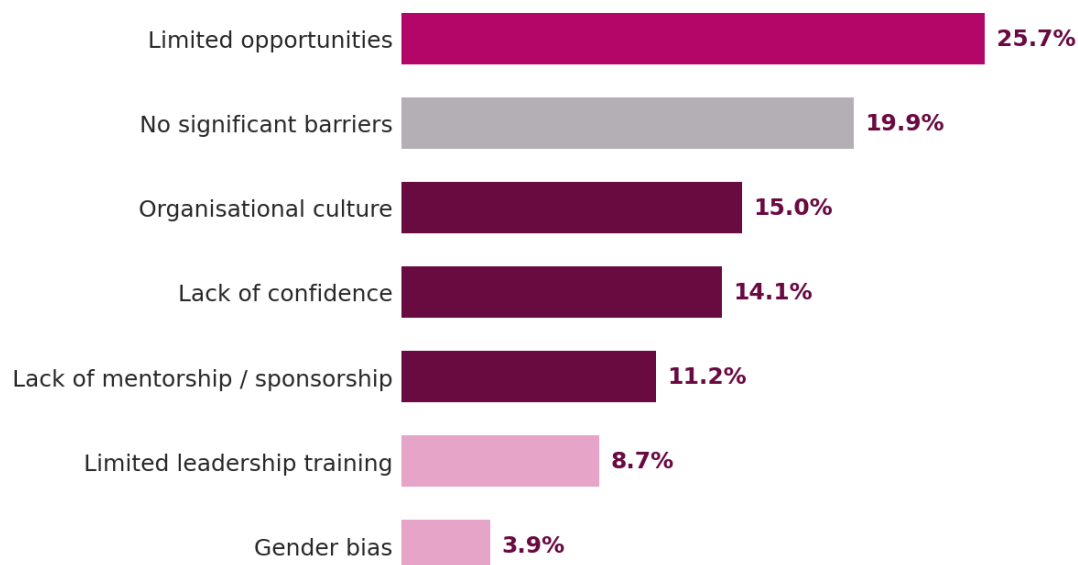
The leadership gap: from responsibility to authority

Leadership is already part of the experience for some women in the survey, but it is not yet the norm. Nearly half (49.5%) hold no leadership position today. Another 22.8% have held one previously. Among those currently in leadership, 13.6% are team leads or supervisors, 5.8% hold executive positions (C-suite, Director, VP), 4.9% are in technical leadership (Tech Lead, Principal Engineer) and 3.4% are in senior management.

**FIGURE 4.1 - CURRENT LEADERSHIP DISTRIBUTION**

The shape of this distribution matters as much as the headline figure. Leadership presence does not decline gradually across levels - it drops off sharply after the first rung. 13.6% hold team-lead roles, but that falls to single digits at every level above it. This is consistent with a pattern already established in this report: individual effort and early-stage progression are relatively accessible, but the mechanisms required to convert that progression into senior authority - sponsorship, structured advancement, institutional trust - are not.

Access to opportunity is the most frequently cited barrier to advancing further. One in four respondents (25.7%) point to limited opportunities as their greatest obstacle to leadership. Organisational culture follows at 15.0%, lack of confidence at 14.1% and lack of mentorship or sponsorship at 11.2%.

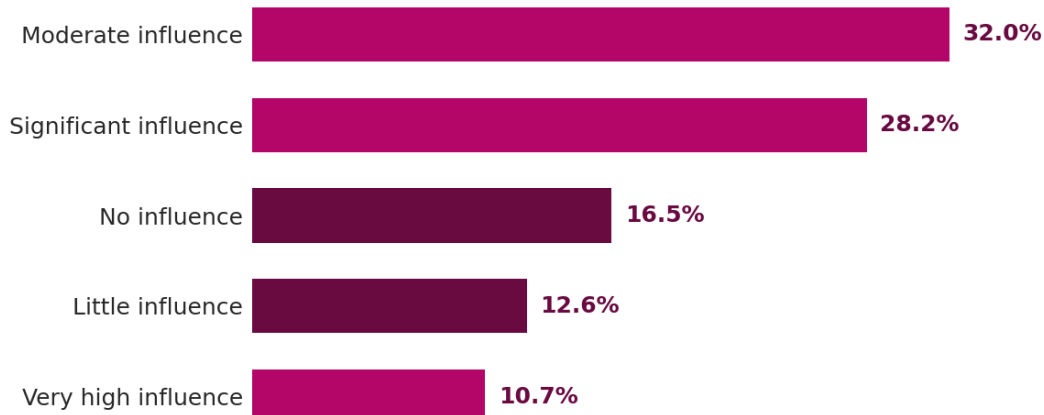
**FIGURE 4.2 - BARRIERS TO ADVANCING INTO TECHNOLOGY LEADERSHIP**

When women do pursue leadership, outcomes split sharply. Over the past three years, 23.3% actively sought a leadership promotion and succeeded, while 12.1% sought one and were rejected. But the more significant figure sits outside that comparison entirely: nearly 40% did not apply for a higher position at all - not because they lacked ambition (76.7% believe they will reach senior leadership), but because rigid organisational cultures, absent senior sponsorship and opaque promotion frameworks make applying feel like a low-odds bet rather than a viable next step.

That non-application rate is arguably a more urgent finding than the rejection rate. A rejected application is at least a data point an organisation can act on. A woman who never applies leaves no data point at all: the barrier stays invisible to the institution that created it.

Decision-making authority

Do women have a real voice when decisions are made? The data reveals a clear divide between day-to-day team input and high-level strategic direction. A woman can shape a project or influence her team's direction without holding a management title. The survey reflects this: while 16.5% report no influence over workplace decisions and 12.6% report little influence, the largest groups describe their influence as moderate (32.0%) or significant (28.2%). A further 10.7% report very high influence.

**FIGURE 4.3 - LEVEL OF INFLUENCE OVER WORKPLACE DECISIONS**

Together, 70.9% of respondents report at least moderate influence: informal authority is clearly more available than formal title. That is a genuinely positive finding, and it is worth stating plainly. But it also sharpens the leadership-gap question rather than resolving it. If the majority of women already exercise real influence day to day, the 49.5% without a formal leadership title looks less like an ambition or capability gap and more like a recognition gap - informal authority that organisations are not yet converting into formal roles, titles or compensation.

That distinction is what makes the confidence numbers worth reading carefully. 76.7% are confident or extremely confident they will reach senior leadership within five years, and 78.3% believe their long-term career ambitions are achievable. Confidence at this scale, against a leadership base this thin, is not naïveté - it is evidence that women already see themselves exercising leadership-level influence informally, and expect the formal recognition to eventually catch up to a reality they are already living.

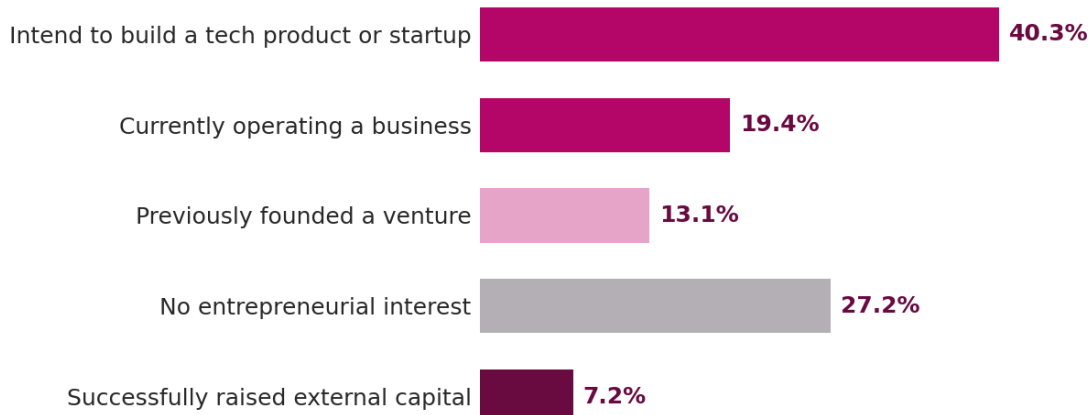
"There have been situations where I have felt that I needed to demonstrate more evidence before my judgment was trusted, particularly when making decisions involving significant advertising budgets or performance strategy. In those situations, I learned very quickly that confidence has to be backed by competence."

- Onyeka Nnabugwu

That account gives texture to the influence data above: even within the 70.9% who report moderate-to-very-high influence, that influence can come with a higher evidentiary bar than it would for a male colleague in the same role. Competence has to be demonstrated more explicitly before judgment is trusted by default.

The founder journey: high ambition, scarce capital

For some women, progression does not mean climbing an organisational ladder. Entrepreneurship offers another way to build authority, create opportunities and shape the technology ecosystem.

**FIGURE 4.4 - ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTIVITY AND INTENT**

40.3% intend to build and launch a tech startup, digital solution or independent product. 19.4% are actively operating a tech-enabled business today and 13.1% have previously founded a tech venture. Only 27.2% report zero entrepreneurial interest - meaning nearly three-quarters of respondents have either built, are building, or intend to build something of their own.

But ambition and execution diverge sharply beyond the earliest stage. While close to a third of respondents have actively launched or tested a solution, fewer than 6% have moved a business into a growth or established phase. Among the barriers respondents identify, funding ranks highest at 43.6%, customer acquisition follows at 30.3% and gaps in business or commercial skills account for 19.1%.

Of those who actively sought external funding, more than two-thirds were unsuccessful. Only 7.2% of respondents managed to raise external capital. Read against the funding barrier figure above, this is not a pipeline problem where women are not attempting to raise; it is a conversion problem where the overwhelming majority who do attempt it fail. In an ecosystem where female-led startups already receive a fraction of early-stage venture capital continent-wide, this data suggests African women founders are largely bootstrapping resource-intensive digital businesses out of pocket, which caps how many of the 40.3% with founder intent will ever reach the growth stage, regardless of the quality of their ideas.

"As a woman founder, I've learned that building something ambitious is often easier than accessing the capital and opportunities required to build it at scale. You can have the vision, the track record and a proven need, yet still find yourself having to work harder to establish credibility, build investor trust and make the case for why your ambition is worth backing."

- Ada Nduka Oyom

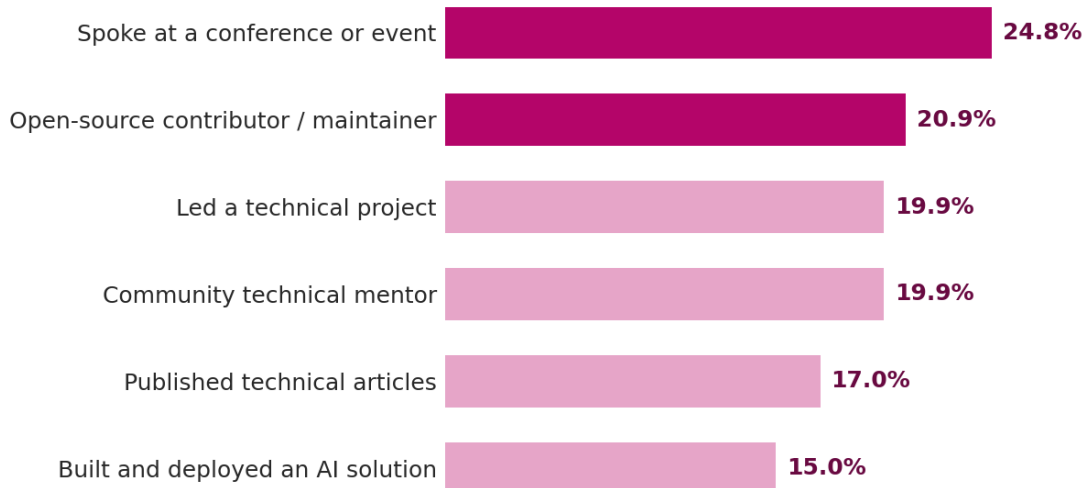
Visibility, community leadership and governance

Beyond the workplace and startup hubs, how are African women shaping the broader ecosystem? Over the past two years, 24.8% of respondents have spoken at a conference or event, 20.9% have contributed to or maintained open-source repositories, 19.9% have led a major technical project



and another 19.9% have served as a community technical mentor. 17.0% have published technical articles or blogs, and 15.0% have built and deployed an AI solution.

FIGURE 4.5 - WAYS WOMEN ARE CONTRIBUTING TO THE WIDER TECH ECOSYSTEM



These figures matter because visibility is part of how expertise gets recognised outside the boundaries of a single employer. Speaking, mentoring, leading technical work and contributing to public technical resources all create ways for women to demonstrate capability and shape others in the ecosystem, often independent of whether their own organisation has formally recognised that capability.

You can be the most recognised person in the room and still have no seat at the table where the room's decisions get made.

But visibility and governance are not the same thing, and the distinction is worth holding onto as the report closes this chapter. Women are clearly building a public presence as contributors, speakers, mentors and technical leaders. The survey did not directly measure presence in formal governance structures, but given how thin formal leadership representation already is (49.5% hold no leadership role at all), it is a real open question whether visibility is converting into a seat at the tables where institutional decisions get made. This chapter has surfaced a version of that same gap more than once: from informal influence without formal title, to funding attempts without funding outcomes, to public visibility without governance access. The pattern repeats at every level - participation is ahead of authority.



CHAPTER FIVE

The Ecosystem Review

Are employers, policies, universities and capital providers actively supporting African women?

The burden of achieving gender parity cannot rest solely on the perseverance of individual women. Individual upskilling, personal initiative and self-advocacy can only go so far when institutional systems remain unsupportive.

Building a genuinely inclusive tech sector requires an ecosystem that enables women to enter, progress and lead, rather than placing the responsibility for that progress entirely on the individual. In this chapter, we examine the readiness of the primary pillars of the African technology landscape: employers, government policy, academia, communities and institutional investors. The findings point to an ecosystem where that support is uneven. Some parts are providing meaningful support, particularly technology communities and networks, while other areas - including workplace policies, academic preparation and government support - receive a more mixed assessment.

KEY METRICS

73.3%

The community lifeline: women who are active members of tech networks, ranked the most effective enabler in the ecosystem

35.0%

The DEI blindspot: employers with formal diversity, equity and inclusion policies in place

62.1%

Policy disconnect: women unsure about, or reporting no benefit from, government support

57.3%

The university gap: women citing a lack of practical, hands-on learning as the greatest flaw in academic technical training

Employer practices

The workplace is one of the clearest places to see whether inclusion translates into the everyday experience of women in technology. On the surface, there are signs of progress: 48.3% agree their company offers equal opportunities for career advancement, 48.3% believe hiring processes are inclusive and 49.3% agree that women are adequately represented in leadership.

**FIGURE 5.1 - EMPLOYER PRACTICES WOMEN EXPERIENCE IN THE WORKPLACE**

Share of respondents who agree with each statement.

But these numbers become less encouraging when the focus shifts from getting women in to supporting what happens after they arrive. Only 42.9% say their employer invests in their professional learning and development, and only 41.9% believe promotion decisions are fair and transparent - meaning 58.1% sit in neutrality or open disagreement on the single mechanism that determines advancement.

The pattern here is now a familiar one in this report: recruitment and representation score relatively stronger, while the systems that determine how women develop and move forward score weaker. A workplace can bring women through the door without giving them equivalent clarity on development, promotion or long-term progression - the same entry-versus-conversion gap this report has traced through career progression, compensation and leadership.

Formal policy tells the same story from a different angle. Only 35.0% say their organisation has formal DEI policies in place, and almost a third - 32.5% - are unsure whether such policies even exist. That uncertainty is itself informative: a policy that employees cannot confirm exists functions, in practice, the same as no policy at all.

"Structured mentorship and sponsorship programmes tend to move the needle the most, because they address progression, not just entry. Transparent promotion criteria matter too - when people can see exactly what advancement requires, it removes a lot of the ambiguity that disproportionately holds women back."

- Titilope Salami, HR Professional

Community infrastructure: support beyond the workplace

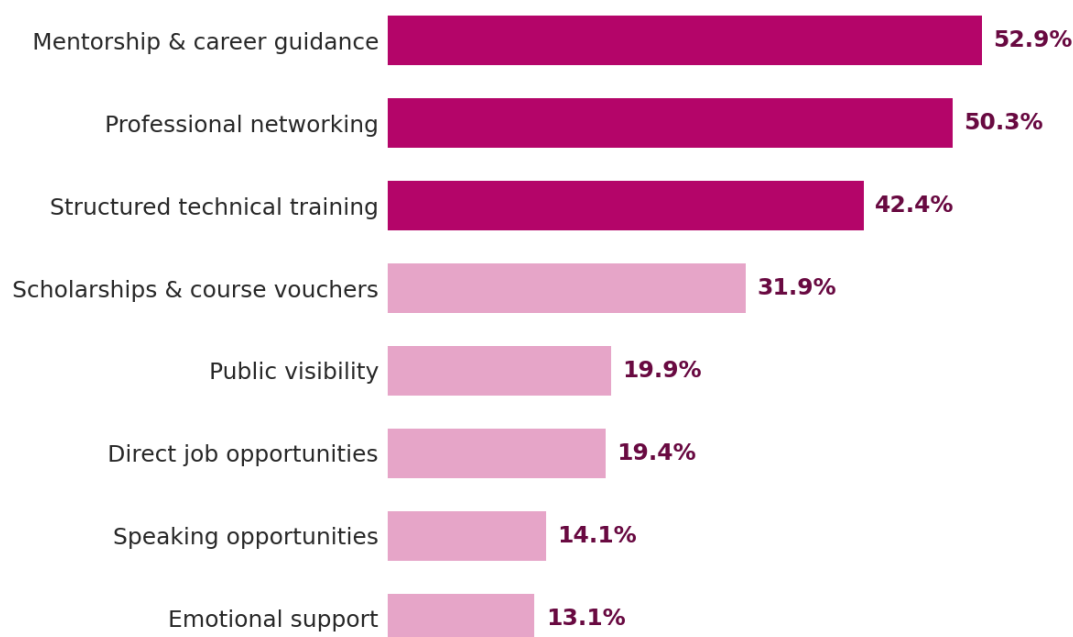
Outside formal workplaces and educational institutions, tech communities - including She Code Africa - have become a critical source of support for women building careers in the sector. Nearly three out of four respondents (73.3%) are active members of tech communities, turning to them for



resources that are otherwise difficult to access: mentorship, professional connections, technical training and visibility.

Among community members, 52.9% have received mentorship or career guidance - the most commonly accessed form of support. Professional networking follows closely at 50.3%, and 42.4% have accessed structured technical training. Other forms of support include scholarships and course vouchers (31.9%), public visibility (19.9%), direct job opportunities (19.4%), speaking opportunities (14.1%) and emotional support (13.1%).

FIGURE 5.2 - SUPPORT WOMEN RECEIVE THROUGH TECHNOLOGY COMMUNITIES



Read against this report's earlier findings, this section reframes an already-established gap rather than introducing a new one. 52.4% of respondents said earlier that they want a mentor they do not have; here, 52.9% of community members say they have received mentorship through a community.

The implication is direct: communities are not a supplement to institutional mentorship in this ecosystem - for most women who are getting mentored at all, they are the primary source of it. Without these grassroots networks absorbing a function employers and academic institutions are not providing at scale, the female talent pipeline across Africa would likely see a sharp drop in both retention and progression, not just in the count of new entrants.

The institutional divide: academic and policy blindspots

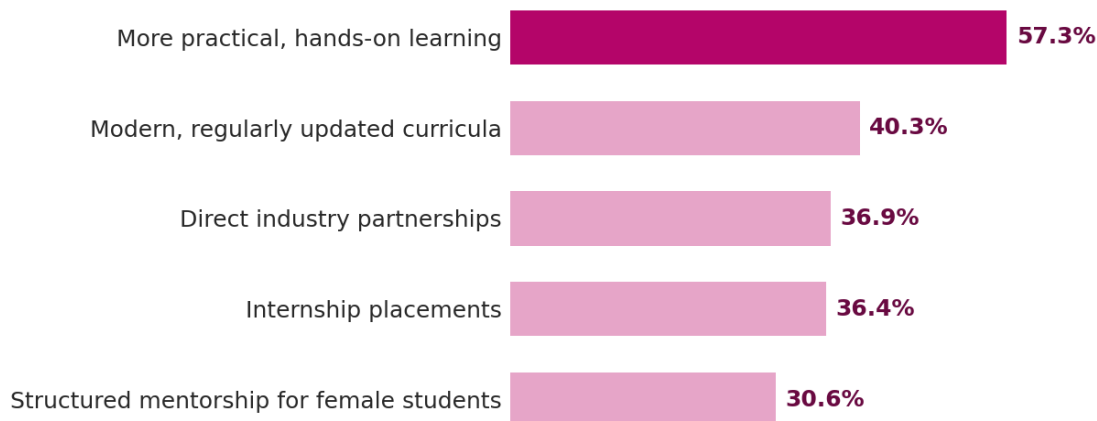
Formal education remains an important entry point into technology, but there is a clear demand for stronger connections between what people learn and the work they eventually encounter in the



industry. Only 32.5% rate the preparation they received from tertiary institutions as very or extremely good; the majority, 67.5%, rate it as moderate, poor or ineffective.

The priorities for improving technical education are concrete and consistent. 57.3% want more practical, hands-on learning - the single most-cited priority - followed by more regularly updated curricula (40.3%), stronger industry partnerships (36.9%), internship opportunities (36.4%) and structured mentorship for female students (30.6%).

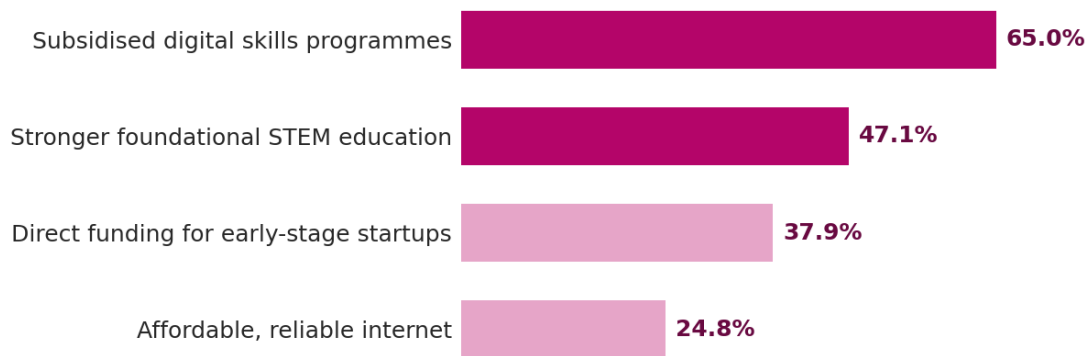
FIGURE 5.3 - WHAT WOMEN WANT FROM TECHNICAL EDUCATION



These priorities describe a desire for education that is far more tightly coupled to how technology work is actually practised, which puts a specific, actionable obligation on academic institutions: fewer purely theoretical curricula, direct partnership with employers, and practical delivery built into degree requirements rather than left to internships alone.

Public policy shows a similar disconnect. Only 37.9% of respondents believe government initiatives have supported women in technology, 38.3% are unsure and 23.8% state definitively that public policy has had zero impact - meaning 62.1% in total see no clear benefit from government action at all. Respondents are, however, specific about where government intervention would matter most.

FIGURE 5.4 - WHERE WOMEN WANT GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION





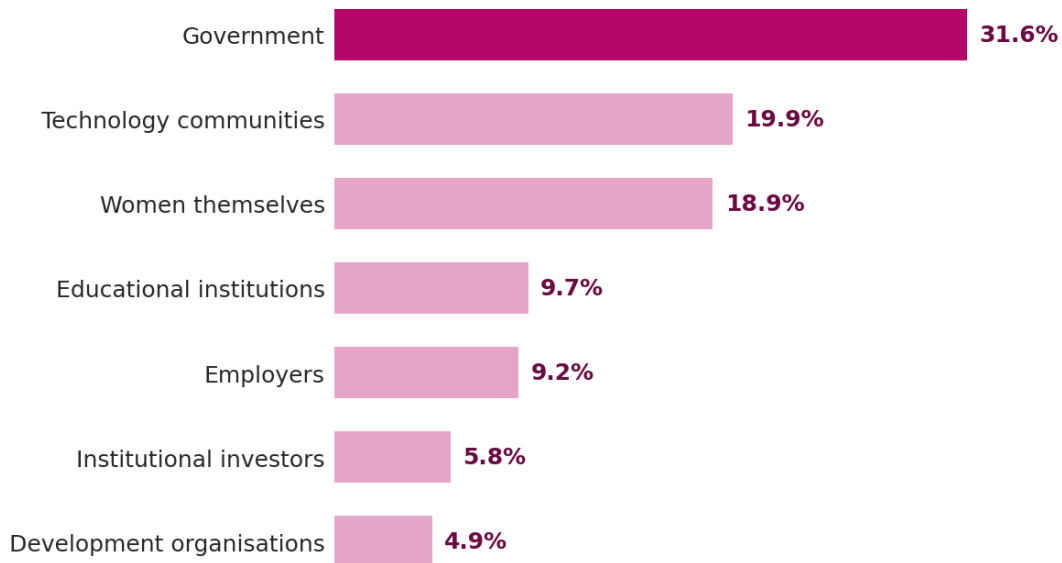
Who is doing the most to support women in tech?

To understand which institutions hold the trust of female talent, we asked respondents to rate the effectiveness of core ecosystem actors. Technology communities ranked highest by a clear margin, with 75.9% rating them as moderately or very effective. Development organisations follow at 58.1%, professional associations at 56.7%, employers at 53.7%, and accelerators and incubators at 53.2%. Ratings drop for investors and venture capital (45.3%) and universities and polytechnics (44.3%). Governments rank lowest of all, at 34.5% effective versus 38.4% rated ineffective or very ineffective.

ECOSYSTEM ACTOR	RATED EFFECTIVE
Technology communities	75.9%
Development organisations	58.1%
Professional associations	56.7%
Employers	53.7%
Accelerators & incubators	53.2%
Investors & venture capital	45.3%
Universities & polytechnics	44.3%
Governments	34.5%

Technology communities emerge as the strongest-performing part of the ecosystem by a wide margin, consistent with the earlier finding that communities are the primary source of mentorship, professional connections, technical training and access to opportunities for most women who have any of these at all.

Government presents the chapter's sharpest contradiction. It receives the lowest effectiveness rating of any actor, yet it is also the actor women believe holds the greatest power to change outcomes: 31.6% name government as having the greatest power to transform outcomes for women in tech, more than double the next-highest answer, technology communities, at 19.9%.

**FIGURE 5.5 - WHO WOMEN BELIEVE HOLDS THE GREATEST POWER TO CHANGE OUTCOMES**

This creates one of the clearest tensions in the ecosystem: the institution women rate as least effective is the same institution they believe has the most latent power to change their circumstances. Communities are delivering real, measured support today - mentorship, networking, training - but they are doing so at the level of the individual and the immediate career. Government, by contrast, operates at the level of policy, funding and structural access: the level at which this report's earlier findings (the funding gap for founders, the absence of formal DEI policy, the weak connection between education and industry) would get addressed at scale.

Communities are proving what works. Government is where the same interventions would need to be funded and made structural.



CHAPTER SIX

Looking Ahead: What Will Shape the Next Generation?

How AI, emerging skills and changing career paths are shaping what comes next.

The next decade of Africa's technology economy will be shaped by rapid changes in how people work, the skills employers need and the technologies businesses are building around. Artificial intelligence is already changing everyday workflows, while cybersecurity, machine learning, data and other technical fields are creating new areas of specialisation.

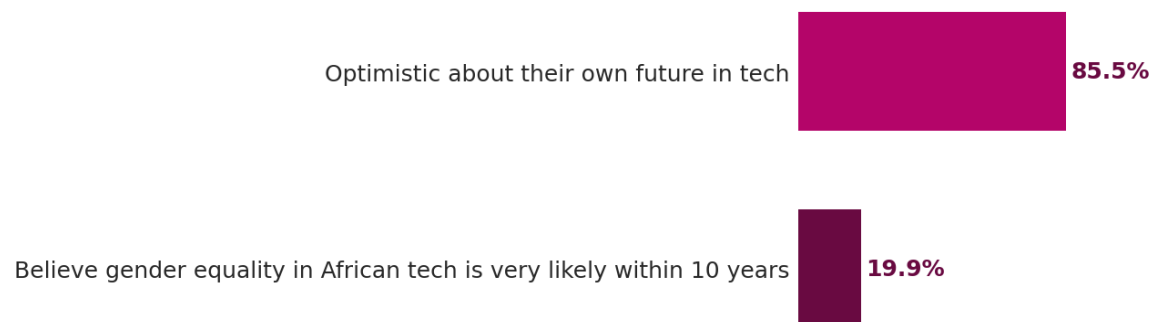
For women building careers in this environment, adaptability is becoming increasingly important. The women represented in this survey are already responding to that shift: 75.2% use AI tools daily and 79.1% are actively investing in learning new skills. Many are also looking beyond immediate changes in the industry, with ambitions to deepen their technical expertise, move into leadership and build technology businesses of their own.

KEY METRICS

75.2% use AI tools daily	79.1% are actively investing in learning new skills
85.5% are optimistic about their own future in technology	19.9% believe gender equality in African tech is very likely within ten years

But confidence in an individual career does not extend automatically to confidence in the wider ecosystem. 85.5% are optimistic about their own prospects in technology. Confidence in the ecosystem is far more measured: only 19.9% believe it is very likely Africa will achieve significant gender equality in tech within ten years, and 37.4% are unsure.

FIGURE 6.1 - THE CONFIDENCE GAP: PERSONAL OUTLOOK VERSUS ECOSYSTEM OUTLOOK



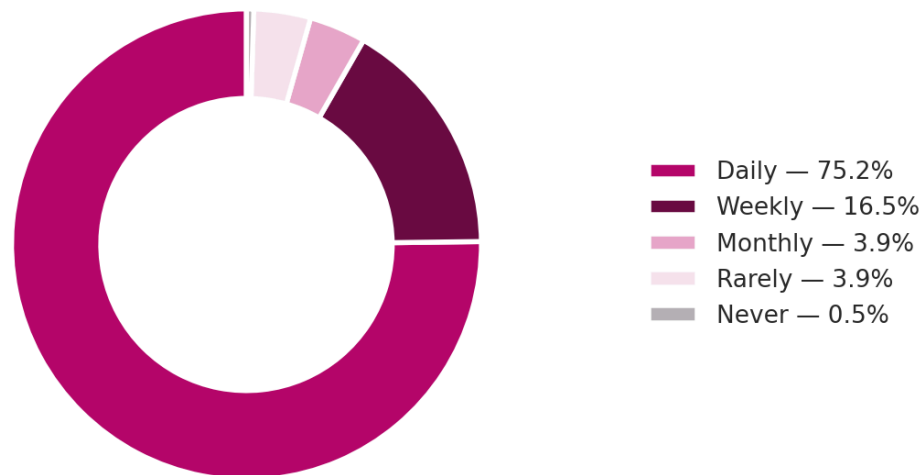


That gap between personal optimism and structural confidence is the chapter's real subject: women trust their own capacity to adapt more than they trust the ecosystem to change around them. The future of women in African tech will therefore depend on two things happening simultaneously - women continuing to adapt to a changing industry, and the ecosystem creating the conditions for that ambition to translate into lasting careers, leadership and opportunity.

Artificial intelligence in practice

Discussions of AI readiness in emerging markets often ask whether African talent has access to modern tooling. This data answers that question directly: 75.2% use AI tools daily, and a further 16.5% use them weekly. Only 0.5% - a single respondent - say they never use AI tools.

FIGURE 6.2 - HOW FREQUENTLY WOMEN USE AI TOOLS



The frequency of use points to a technology that has become part of everyday work, not something being explored at the margins. Women are using AI for code debugging, data analysis, content creation and technical research, bringing these tools into the way they solve problems and get work done.

The effect on output is just as clear: over 70% report that AI has significantly improved their productivity, and a further 22.3% report moderate improvement. Fewer than 4% observed no effect at all. In resource-constrained environments, where women are frequently juggling multiple roles on lean teams, AI is functioning less as a novelty and more as a capacity multiplier, closing some of the gap left by understaffed teams and limited support.

"Automation could also disproportionately affect women if women are concentrated in roles that are easier to automate and are not given opportunities to reskill."

- Tumininu Dada

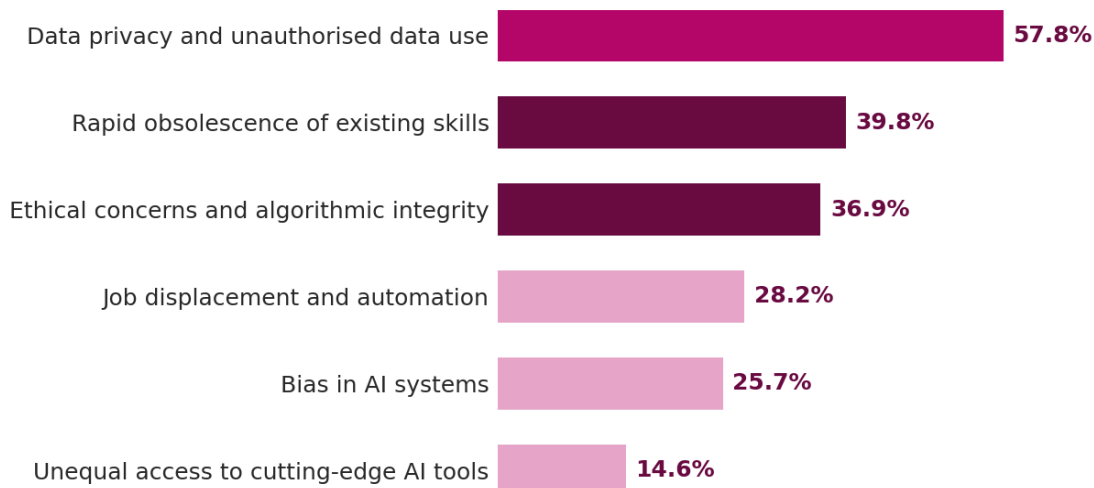
That point is the necessary counterweight to the productivity numbers above: the same technology delivering a measurable capacity gain today is also the one most likely to eliminate the roles women are concentrated in tomorrow, unless reskilling access keeps pace with adoption.



The AI dilemma

The benefits of AI are clear, but so are the concerns around how quickly the technology is changing the way people work. Data privacy and unauthorised data use is the top concern, cited by 57.8% of respondents, well ahead of everything else. This is followed by fear of skills becoming obsolete (39.8%), ethical concerns about how AI systems are built and used (36.9%), job displacement (28.2%), bias in AI systems (25.7%) and unequal access to advanced tools (14.6%).

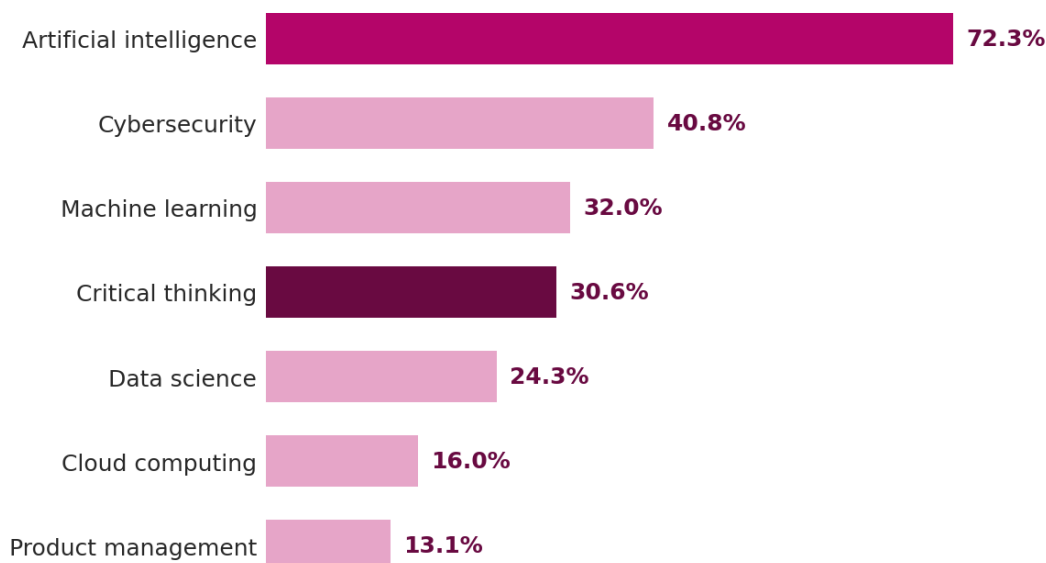
FIGURE 6.3 - TOP CONCERNS SURROUNDING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE



The skills-obsolescence concern is a rational read of the pace of change: tools that are valuable today may need to be supplemented or replaced as adoption widens. The bias concern, cited by 25.7%, reflects a different and more structural worry - whether the systems increasingly mediating hiring, evaluation and opportunity are themselves reproducing the same disparities this report has spent five chapters documenting.

The skills women are preparing for

That pressure to keep learning is reflected in the skills women believe will matter most over the next five years. Artificial intelligence ranks first, with 72.3% identifying it as a critical future skill. Cybersecurity follows at 40.8% and machine learning at 32.0%, alongside critical thinking at 30.6%, data science at 24.3%, cloud computing at 16.0% and product management at 13.1%.

**FIGURE 6.4 - CORE SKILLS FOR THE NEXT FIVE YEARS**

The mix is notable: four of the top five are deep technical domains, but critical thinking - a capability that outlives any single tool - sits right alongside them at 30.6%. Women are not just preparing for the next specific technology; they are preparing for the fact that whatever comes after this one will require the same adaptive capacity again.

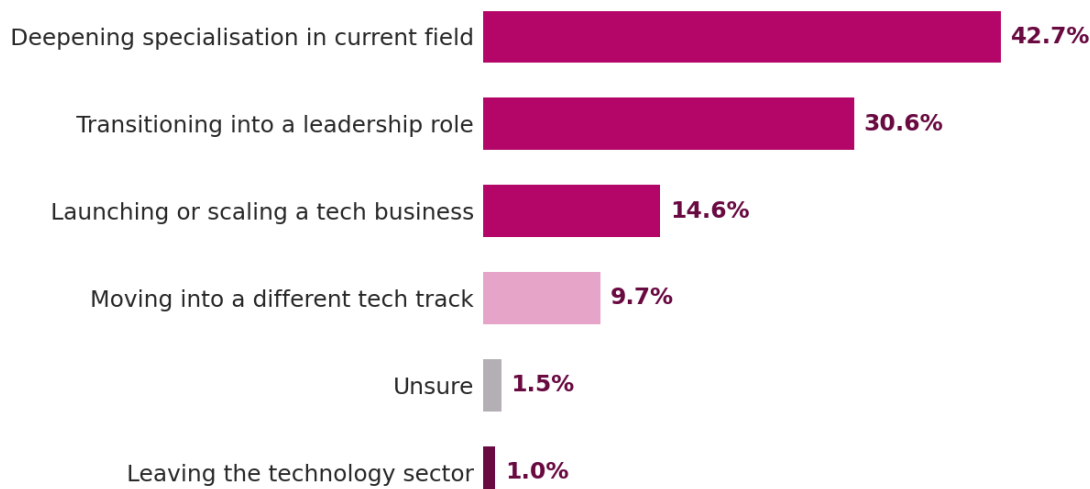
Women are already acting on this. 79.1% are actively investing in learning new skills and a further 10.7% are planning to start. Only 1.0% say they are not investing at all. Interest extends beyond AI itself into adjacent domains: healthtech (28.6%), fintech (18.4%), agritech (17.5%) and robotics/IoT (13.6%), alongside AI (68.4%) and cybersecurity (35.9%).

"Maybe not just tech skills but skills required to excel in tech - AI literacy and prompt engineering, data literacy and storytelling, project management, critical thinking, and perhaps most importantly, adaptability. People who can learn, unlearn and quickly adapt will have more advantage."

- Seyifunmi Oderinde, HR

Where women see themselves in five years

The skills women are building map closely onto where they expect their careers to go. 42.7% expect to deepen specialisation in their current field, the single most common path. 30.6% expect to move into leadership, 14.6% plan to launch or scale a tech business and 9.7% expect to move into a different area of technology entirely.

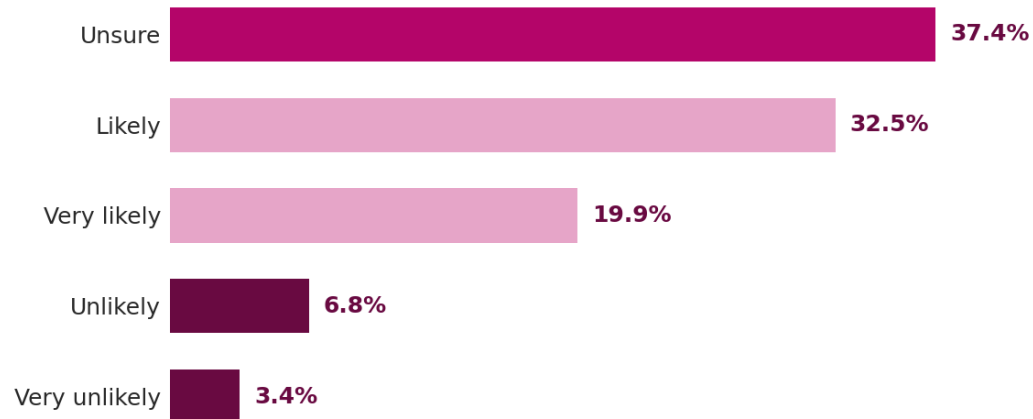
**FIGURE 6.5 - FIVE-YEAR CAREER EXPECTATIONS**

The near-total absence of attrition intent - only 1.0% plan to leave the sector entirely - is one of this report's more consequential findings, and it is easy to read past given everything else in the chart. It confirms what the demographic data implied: this is not a workforce at risk of losing interest in tech. It is a workforce whose continued presence depends almost entirely on whether the ecosystem can convert their stated plans - leadership, specialisation, entrepreneurship - into actual outcomes, rather than on whether they want to stay.

There is also strong confidence behind these plans. 85.5% are optimistic about their future in technology, including 61.7% who are extremely optimistic and 23.8% who are very optimistic.

Uncertainty in the system

Women are considerably more confident about their own future than they are about the pace of change across the wider technology ecosystem. 85.5% are optimistic about their personal future in technology. Just 19.9% believe it is very likely that Africa will achieve significant gender equality in technology within the next ten years. A further 32.5% believe it is likely, 37.4% are unsure and 10.2% consider it unlikely or very unlikely.

**FIGURE 6.6 - LIKELIHOOD OF ACHIEVING GENDER EQUALITY IN AFRICAN TECH WITHIN TEN YEARS**

The gap between these two outlooks is the chapter's core finding, and it is consistent with almost everything measured earlier in the report: women trust their own ability to learn, adapt and build independently - the same individual-effort strength identified in the career-growth data (55.8% cite skills, 35.9% cite initiative). What they remain unconvinced of is whether employers, policy institutions and investors will actually dismantle the structural barriers - funding access, sponsorship, transparent promotion - that have held mid-career and senior women back to this point.

Priorities for the next decade

This generation of African women in tech is not waiting for institutional permission to build. They are adopting AI to drive productivity, acquiring skills in cybersecurity and machine learning, and actively targeting leadership and venture creation. But individual resilience cannot substitute for systemic reform. If the ecosystem does not address data privacy protection, provide corporate-sponsored upskilling and establish clear promotion tracks, talent will keep carrying an unsustainable double burden: mastering tomorrow's technological shifts while still navigating yesterday's structural workplace barriers.



CHAPTER SEVEN

From Insight to Action

What needs to change, and who needs to make it happen.

Data is only as valuable as the decisions it informs. The findings across this report point to a technology ecosystem where women are participating, building skills and pursuing advancement, but where access to opportunity remains uneven. Gender bias remains the most frequently identified barrier to opportunity, cited by 48.1% of respondents. Professional networks and mentorship are also significant gaps, and access to capital continues to constrain women building businesses.

FIGURE 7.1 - THE STRUCTURAL ROADBLOCKS WOMEN IDENTIFY



Women's priorities are concentrated around access and progression. Practical digital skills training ranks highest, with 52.4% identifying it as an intervention that could have an immediate impact, followed by structured mentorship networks at 37.4% and stronger STEM education for girls at 33.5%. These priorities sit alongside the wider challenges identified throughout the report: finding meaningful entry points into the industry, building professional networks, accessing funding, progressing into leadership and working in environments where opportunities and rewards are distributed fairly.

FIGURE 7.2 - PRIORITY INTERVENTIONS IDENTIFIED BY RESPONDENTS





Addressing these issues requires coordinated action across the institutions that shape a woman's journey through technology. Education and training providers shape how prepared people are on entry; employers shape what happens once they arrive; investors shape which businesses get capital; communities connect women to skills, networks and opportunity; and governments shape the policy and infrastructure environment underneath all of it. Each actor has a distinct point of leverage - but as the data throughout this report shows, none of them are sufficient alone, and progress will depend on those points of influence being strengthened rather than treated as separate interventions.

The nine core pillars of ecosystem reform

Across the findings and recommendations gathered from women in this survey, nine areas emerge consistently as priorities for improving participation and progression.

- **Access to jobs and career pathways:** clearer routes from training and education into paid work, internships and sustainable career opportunities.
- **Mentorship, networks and sponsorship:** professional relationships remain important for career guidance, access to opportunities and progression into more senior roles.
- **Leadership and upward mobility:** participation needs to translate into advancement, with clearer pathways to promotion, decision-making authority and leadership.
- **Funding and capital access:** women building technology businesses need greater access to the funding and commercial networks required to start and grow.
- **Workplace pay and inclusion:** fair compensation, transparent promotion processes and inclusive workplace practices are central to retaining women and supporting long-term progression.
- **Practical skills and STEM education:** education and training need to remain connected to the skills and tools being used across the technology industry.
- **Policy and accountability:** government action matters in areas including skills development, infrastructure, equal opportunity and support for women entering technology and entrepreneurship.
- **Digital infrastructure and hardware:** access to reliable internet, devices and other basic tools remains part of the foundation for participation in the digital economy.
- **Care support and flexibility:** flexible work and support for care responsibilities can make it easier for women to remain and progress in the workforce.

These priorities are interconnected, and treating them as separable is where most interventions fail. A woman may have the skills to enter technology but lack access to her first opportunity. Another may have built a career but struggle to progress without sponsorship or transparent promotion processes. A founder may have a viable business but lack the capital or networks to scale it. Strengthening one pillar without the others caps the overall effect, which is precisely the pattern this report has surfaced at every level: individual capability consistently outpaces institutional conversion.



Access to opportunity

For many women, the challenge begins before a career has properly started. Training and education can provide a foundation, but the transition from learning into paid work remains an important part of the journey.

Practical digital skills were identified by 52.4% as the intervention most likely to create immediate impact, and the emphasis on practical preparation is consistent with how women assess their educational experience. Only 32.5% felt their tertiary education had prepared them very or extremely well for the technology industry. The areas they would most like to see strengthened are practical, production-oriented learning, modern curricula, stronger relationships between institutions and industry, internships and mentorship.

This points to a need for closer connections between the places where women learn and the places where they eventually work. Universities, training providers and technology communities all have a role in closing that gap - helping women build portfolios, gain practical experience and understand real pathways into different technology careers. Employers can contribute by creating more early-career opportunities, rather than leaving the transition from training to employment entirely to the individual to solve alone.

Access also depends on the basic infrastructure required to participate. Reliable connectivity and appropriate devices remain part of the infrastructure of a digital career, particularly for women learning outside formal institutions or entering the industry without employer-provided resources. Expanding access to skills without addressing these practical constraints will continue to leave some women at the edge of the opportunity being created.

Areas for action

For employers and tech companies

- **Remove unnecessary barriers to entry:** build clearer pathways for early-career talent through internships, apprenticeships and structured entry-level programmes, including partnerships with technology communities and training organisations.
- **Make pay and progression more transparent:** establish clear salary ranges and promotion criteria, with regular reviews to identify disparities in compensation and advancement.
- **Create space for continuous learning:** as technology and the skills required to work in it continue to change, professional development should be part of the employee experience rather than left entirely to personal time.
- **Support flexibility:** provide opportunities for employees to develop relevant skills while maintaining flexible and hybrid work arrangements where roles allow.

"We are not asking organisations to create a separate playing field for women. We just need them to remove unnecessary barriers and create the conditions for everyone to have a fair opportunity to succeed."

- Seyifunmi Oderinde, HR



For governments and policymakers

- **Modernise STEM education:** make technology education more practical and strengthen links between educational institutions and industry.
- **Strengthen equal opportunity protections:** improve policies and enforcement around discrimination, equal pay and workplace inclusion.
- **Expand digital access:** make reliable internet, devices and other essential digital tools more affordable and accessible.
- **Support women-led businesses:** expand funding and business support for women starting and scaling technology businesses.

For venture capital and angel investors

- **Examine the investment pipeline:** track women's representation from sourcing through investment to identify where women-led businesses are being lost.
- **Broaden investment networks:** build relationships with women founders and the communities, accelerators and networks where they operate.
- **Strengthen diversity in decision-making:** increase women's representation across investment teams and decision-making structures.

For technology communities

- **Connect skills to employment:** build stronger pathways from training into internships, apprenticeships and jobs.
- **Move from mentorship to sponsorship:** create structures for experienced professionals to actively advocate for women pursuing leadership and visibility, not just advise them.
- **Track long-term outcomes:** follow participants beyond programmes to understand how interventions translate into employment, progression and entrepreneurship.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Building the Future Together

What the next decade of African technology can look like when women have the opportunity to shape it.

Women are already an established part of Africa's technology economy. Across 14 countries, 206 respondents and a series of qualitative conversations, this research captures women building careers across technical and non-technical roles, developing new skills, adapting to emerging technologies and pursuing opportunities for advancement.

What emerges across the findings is a clear tension between individual ambition and the conditions surrounding it. Women are investing in their careers and preparing for a changing industry, but access to progression, leadership, capital, professional development and supportive workplace practices remains uneven. Individual effort opens doors, but the systems around those opportunities determine how far women are able to walk through them.

The challenge therefore extends beyond encouraging more women into technology; participation is not the constraint this report identifies. It is creating an environment in which women can build sustainable careers, move into positions of influence, start and grow businesses, and remain part of the industry as it evolves. That requires employers, governments, investors, educational institutions and communities to examine the structures through which opportunity is created and distributed, not just the ones through which women enter.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The pipeline

91% are under 35, 84.5% hold tertiary degrees, and over half entered via self-learning or community ecosystems

The friction

68% earn under US\$5,000 annually, with burnout driven largely by continuous, uncompensated upskilling

The AI shift

75.2% use AI tools daily and 79.1% are actively investing in learning new skills

The opportunity

52.4% identify practical digital skills training as the priority intervention, then mentorship (37.4%) and STEM education (33.5%)

Priorities for the next decade: moving beyond performative inclusion

Building a more equitable digital economy requires sustained action across the institutions that shape women's participation and progression in technology. As the ecosystem moves toward 2030, these commitments need to be measurable and enforceable, not aspirational.

- **Employers must build more equitable workplaces:** clearer promotion pathways, transparent compensation practices, meaningful professional development and flexible working arrangements can help women remain in technology and progress into more senior roles.



- **Governments must strengthen the foundations:** practical STEM education, accessible digital skills programmes, reliable connectivity and stronger protections around equal opportunity can expand women's ability to participate in the digital economy.
- **Investors must widen access to capital:** women founders need stronger pathways into funding and the networks that support business growth. Investors can examine their sourcing and decision-making processes and build relationships with the communities where women entrepreneurs are developing businesses.
- **Communities must continue connecting women to opportunity:** technology communities already play an important role in mentorship, networking, technical training and career support. Strengthening the connection between these programmes and employment, leadership and entrepreneurship opportunities can extend their impact.

The ambition for 2030 should not be measured only by how many women enter technology, but by how many are able to remain, progress, lead and build within it.

"I do not think African tech needs another conversation about whether women belong here. They already do. The question now is whether we are willing to build an ecosystem where they have enough opportunity, capital, visibility and power to shape what African technology becomes."

- Tumininu Dada

To the women building Africa's tomorrow

To the women whose experiences and perspectives have shaped this research: your contribution to Africa's technology economy is already visible across the industry. You are building careers, learning new technologies, starting businesses, leading teams, contributing to communities and still finding new ways into an industry that continues to change around you. The findings in this report reflect both that ambition and the realities that come with pursuing it.

Keep learning. Build relationships that expand your opportunities. Make your work visible. Seek out spaces where you can grow, lead and contribute to decisions that affect the industry. And where the opportunity exists, create room for the women coming behind you.

The future of African technology will be shaped by the people building it today. Women are already part of that work. The task now is ensuring they have the access, support and influence to take it further.



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She Code Africa

Bridging the gender gap in African technology since 2016.

She Code Africa (SCA) is a pan-African non-profit organisation on a mission to bridge the gender gap in tech by equipping African girls and women with access to digital skills in technology and fostering economic independence. Founded in 2016, SCA has equipped over 65,000 women and grown into a community of over 30,000 members across nearly 20 African countries, working to close the gap between women's participation in tech and their access to progression, leadership and capital.

SHE CODE AFRICA IN NUMBERS

65,000+

women equipped with digital skills

30,000+

community members

~20

African countries reached

2016

year founded

The State of Women in African Tech Report 2026 is part of that ongoing work: a research-driven effort to move the conversation about women in African tech beyond visibility, toward the structural conditions - mentorship, sponsorship, fair compensation, transparent progression, access to capital - that determine whether women stay, grow and lead in the sector.

This report reflects the direct perspectives of 206 women across 14 countries, and stands as a resource for anyone building a more equitable technology ecosystem: employers, policymakers, investors, educators, and the communities doing the work every day.



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